THY KINGDOM COME

STORY + SCRIPTURE COMPANION

A REFERENCE FOR THE DRAFTING AND REVISION OF THE NOVEL

KEPT BY ITS AUTHOR · REVISED AS THE MANUSCRIPT REVISES ITSELF

WHAT THIS COMPANION IS

This is a working reference for a novel about a Christian empire, kept by the person writing it. It exists because *Thy Kingdom Come* cannot be written honestly by someone guessing at scripture, and it cannot be written well by someone who has only absorbed the version of scripture that power finds convenient. So the companion does two jobs at once. It teaches the book, patiently and from the beginning, as literature and as history and as an argument that has never stopped arguing with itself. And it keeps a record of what Dominion does to that book once it has the authority to quote it.

It is not a devotional and it is not a study guide. Nothing in here asks you to arrive at a settled conclusion about God, and nothing in here will hand you a single meaning for a passage that has been fought over for two thousand years. Where a reading is contested, the contest is printed. Where the text is stranger or more violent or more tender than its reputation, that is printed too. You are not being catechized; you are being handed summaries, analysis, references and tools that send you back to the text itself.

Neither is it a character worksheet with the serial numbers filed off. The character sections do not ask what Eden's favorite color is. They ask what she believes God wants from her, who taught her that, what it would cost her to be wrong, and which chapter is where the answer changes. Those questions are the same ones the scripture sections have been rehearsing all along, which is the point of putting them in one volume.

Above all it is a book you are permitted to ruin. Write in the margins, argue with the entries, cross out anything the drafting proves false, and date the page when you do. The manuscript is the authority here, and this companion serves it. When the two disagree, the manuscript wins and this book gets amended.

"Every empire that has ever quoted a holy book has also decided which parts of it were quotable."

WHAT IT IS NOT

A devotional.

A curriculum.

A settled theology.

An apologetic, in either direction.

A book with a right answer at the back.

MARGINALIA

HOW TO USE IT

There is an order to this book, and it is worth respecting the first time through. The parts move outward from the text itself to the empire that interprets it, then inward again to the characters who have to live inside that interpretation, and finally to the manuscript, where all of it either earns its place or gets cut. You can read a single entry in ten minutes and you can spend an afternoon on one. Both are legitimate uses.

Work in one of two modes. In *study mode* you are simply learning, reading an entry with no scene in mind, letting the marginalia fill up with whatever surprises you. In *drafting mode* you come in with a scene that is not working, find the reading cluster or the doctrine page that touches it, and take only what you need. The trackers at the back exist so that the second mode stays fast: they are the memory of the book, and they are worthless unless you write in them the same day you discover something.

Discoveries are the actual product. If an entry teaches you that a passage Dominion loves is addressed to slaveholders, or that the woman you had cast as a warning is the only person in her chapter who tells the truth, that is not trivia. It is a change to the novel, and it belongs on the discovery log at the back with a date beside it, so that six months from now you can tell the difference between something you decided and something you merely absorbed.

Nothing here has to be finished. A half-filled dossier is more useful than a blank one.

THE WORKING ARC

01	Learn the book, before anyone tells you what it means.
02	Recognize its people and its patterns on sight.
03	Watch how power reads it, and what power leaves out.
04	Build Dominion's religion on purpose, doctrine by doctrine.
05	Excavate the characters through what they believe and fear.
06	Excavate the relationships through their competing obligations.
07	Apply it to the manuscript, then record what changed.

TWO MODES

Study. No scene in mind. Read, gloss, follow the cross-references.

Drafting. A scene that resists. Take only what the scene needs and go.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Discovery Log, p. 431; Does This Serve TKC?, p. 438.

READING THE PAGE

The layout of this companion carries meaning, and once you have learned the five signals below you will be able to tell at a glance whether you are reading the text, reading the Empire, reading an argument that has no settled answer, or looking at space that belongs to you. The signals hold in black and white, because most of this book will be photocopied at some point in its life.

INFORMATION

Plain roman type, no rule beside it. This is the text and its history reported as plainly as the material allows, and where the material is disputed the entry says so rather than choosing for you.

SCRIPTURE

> *Italic behind a single fine rule. Quoted text always looks like this, and the reference sits beneath it in small tracked capitals so you can find the passage without hunting.*
>
> GENESIS 3.16

DOMINION

> WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH IT
>
> A heavy rule, and the only heavy rule in the book. Anything marked this way is the Empire's reading rather than the text's, which means it is a decision someone made and a decision the novel is free to expose.

CONTESTED

> CONTESTED ✣
>
> A broken frame, meaning the companion is not deciding. **Contested** always names a biblical, historical, linguistic, or theological dispute among real readers — it is not the same as **Possible**, which marks an unapproved idea of your own. Serious readings are laid side by side with the people who hold them, and you may decide what Dominion believes, or leave the question open until you understand it well enough to answer.

YOURS

Ruled space, and the outer column on nearly every working page. If it is ruled, it is yours.

✣ Cross-references always sit at the foot of the outer column, never inside a sentence, so that following one is a choice rather than an interruption.

STATUS AND SOURCE

The signals on the facing page tell you what *kind* of material you are reading. These two systems tell you something different and equally necessary: how settled a claim is, and where it came from. All three run at once and none of them substitutes for another.

I · CLAIM STATUS — INLINE, IN THE SENTENCE ITSELF

[C] **Canon.** Established by the manuscript or by an approved worldbuilding source, and logged. Nothing is canon because it is good; it is canon because it is logged.

[P] **Possible.** A working idea or reading of your own that has not been approved. Freewriting lands here by default and stays here until you move it.

[?] **Question.** Something the manuscript and the companion have not answered, named as open rather than left to look like an answer.

[R] **Research.** A claim needing biblical, historical, linguistic, or worldbuilding verification before it is used as evidence.

II · SOURCE NOTATION — OUTER MARGIN, NEVER INLINE

The outer margin column carries provenance and nothing else: where a statement on that page comes from. Margins are mirrored, so the column is always on the outside edge — left on a left-hand page, right on a right-hand page. A status marker is not provenance; a claim can be Canon and still owe you a source.

BIBLICAL	Book, chapter, and verse — *Gen 3.16*, *Eph 5.21–33*. The passage the page is actually about.
MANUSCRIPT	The witness at issue — *Sinaiticus*, *Vaticanus*, *Masoretic Text*, *Septuagint*, *Dead Sea Scrolls*, or a translation's own textual footnote.
LEXICON	Where a word's range is the question — a standard Greek or Hebrew lexicon, cited by name, never a word-study memory.
COMMENTARY	A named commentary or critical study standing behind a reading, so the reading can be traced and checked.
HISTORICAL	Non-biblical evidence — a canon list, a council, a Roman household code, an ancient Near Eastern parallel.
TKC SOURCE	Your own files, tagged as they are in the ledger — timeline, Dominions, Trials, the men, the manuscript, a draft.

✣ A page with a status marker and no source is unfinished. Say where it came from, or mark it **[R]** and move on.

THE NINE PARTS

Each part carries a mark, printed on every one of its divider pages and in the running head, so that the book can be found by thumb as well as by index. The parts are cumulative: the later ones assume you have at least skimmed the earlier ones, and the trackers at the end assume everything.

The Fall of the United States has its own fourteen pages and its own argument; it is a part, not a chapter of Building Dominion. Opening folios are given only where they are already fixed \u2014 the rest wait until the expanded sections are built.

✣	I	LEARNING THE BIBLE AS A NOVELIST Bible 101, translation, how to read a passage in context, contested readings, and the Bible in three depths: the Quick Bible Map across all sixty-six books, focused study spreads, and deep-dive dossiers.	001
❖	II	THE PEOPLE OF THE TEXT The women, then the men: what they are usually reduced to, and what the text actually gives you to work with.	208
†	III	JESUS, KINGDOM AND POWER Authority, women, bodies, justice and mercy, with the Lord's Prayer taken a clause at a time.	223
▣	IV	EMPIRE AND INTERPRETATION Empires of the Bible, sources of authority, Empire Says versus Biblical Witness, and the passages Dominion weaponizes or buries.	233
✤	V	THE FALL OF THE UNITED STATES The verified Imperial timeline, the competing histories, living memory, and the founder files.	—
☙	VI	BUILDING DOMINION The Empire's actual theology, official doctrine against lived religion, the Doctrine Builder, its liturgy and its vocabulary.	—
◈	VII	THE CHARACTERS The character tier system, full dossiers, focused files, quick records, household and relationship maps, lineage and desire.	—
⌖	VIII	THE MANUSCRIPT Chapter titles, reading clusters by scene type, the chapter-by-chapter companion, and the theology of each act.	—
≡	IX	TRACKERS AND INDEXES Motifs, doctrine, belief arcs, open questions, the canon decision log, and four indexes: scripture, person, motif, chapter.	—

RULES OF THE HOUSE

Seven commitments that keep this companion honest. They are not stylistic preferences; they are the difference between a novel that takes religion seriously and a novel that uses it as set dressing.

I **The text is not the Empire.** Every entry keeps them on separate rules, because the whole engine of this novel is the gap between what a passage says and what an institution can make it do.

II **Contested stays contested.** Where scholars and traditions genuinely disagree, the disagreement is printed and left standing. Dominion may settle a question; the companion does not.

III **No character is an allegory.** Mirrors illuminate; they do not map. Every mirror entry ends with where the parallel breaks, and that break is usually where the character becomes interesting.

IV **Belief has a cost and a teacher.** No character believes anything in this book for free. Someone taught it to them, and something is at stake in keeping it, and both go in the dossier.

V **Discovery outranks plan.** If the research contradicts the outline, the research gets a hearing. The outline is a hypothesis; the companion is where it gets tested.

VI **Nothing enters the novel untested.** Every borrowed symbol, doctrine and parallel has to answer one question before it earns a scene, and that question has its own page at the back.

VII **Possibility is not canon.** Freewriting, inference, thematic association and research notes stay visibly marked until you deliberately approve them. A compelling idea is still only a possibility until it survives the manuscript, the worldbuilding sources, and your own decision — and nothing becomes canon merely because it was surprising, interesting, or written in ink.

"Does this serve Thy Kingdom Come*, or does it only prove I did the reading?"*

MARGINALIA

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Answer these once, in ink, before you read a single entry, and do not go back and tidy the answers later. The point is to have a record of where you started, so that in a year you can see exactly what the reading did to you and how much of it belongs to the novel.

WHAT I ALREADY BELIEVE THE BIBLE SAYS, AND WHERE I LEARNED IT

WHAT I AM AFRAID I WILL FIND IN IT

WHAT DOMINION IS FOR, IN ONE SENTENCE I WOULD DEFEND

WHAT I DO NOT YET UNDERSTAND ABOUT MY OWN NOVEL

Signed and dated by the only authority this book recognizes.

SIGNED

DATE

I

PART ONE ·

LEARNING THE BIBLE AS A NOVELIST

You cannot write about people who have been handed a holy book until you have read the thing they were handed. Start here, and keep your objections in the margin where they belong.

i · What the Bible Actually Is 002

ii · How It Was Assembled 003

iii · The Shape of the Old Testament 004

iv · The Shape of the New Testament 005

v · The Genres, and Why They Matter 006

vi · Translation, and Which One to Trust 007

vii · How to Read a Passage in Context 008

viii · A Worked Example 009

ix · Contested Readings 010

x · The Sixty-Six Books 011

WHAT THE BIBLE ACTUALLY IS

The first thing to understand, and the thing most people who grew up around this book never get told, is that it is not a book. It is a library. Sixty-six separate documents written across something like a thousand years, in three languages, by dozens of hands, for audiences who mostly did not know the other documents existed. Some of it is law written for a small agrarian people. Some of it is court history written to justify a dynasty. Some of it is poetry composed for public grief, some of it is private erotic verse, some of it is prophecy screamed at a government, and some of it is correspondence between a travelling preacher and congregations he was trying to keep from falling apart.

That variety is not a flaw and it is not an embarrassment. It is the single most useful fact you can hold onto as a novelist, because it means the Bible does not have *a* voice, it has an argument going on inside it. Deuteronomy says the righteous prosper; Job says that is a lie told by comfortable men. Ezra says send the foreign wives away; Ruth says a foreign woman is the great-grandmother of the king. Proverbs says wisdom is orderly; Ecclesiastes says everything is vapour and you will be forgotten. Nobody smoothed these out. They sit in the same volume, disagreeing, and every institution that has ever used this book has had to choose which side of those arguments it wanted to be the official one.

That choosing is your novel. Dominion does not have a Bible problem, it has a Bible *strategy*, and it is the same one every scriptural empire has used: elevate the passages about order, hierarchy and submission into the plain and permanent word of God, and reclassify the passages about jubilee, debt release, foreign widows, prophets who insult kings, and a messiah executed by the state as poetry or context-specific instruction that no longer applies. Nothing has to be deleted. The canon stays intact and the pulpit still cites chapter and verse. All that is required is a consistent policy about which parts are read aloud, and to whom.

So read it as a library with a fight in it. When you meet a passage, the useful question is never only what it says, but which side of the internal argument it is on, who benefits from that side winning, and what it would cost a character to have been raised hearing only one half.

"A canon is not what a religion believes. It is the list of things a religion has agreed to keep arguing about."

OT NT

THE NUMBERS

66 books · 39 Old, 27 New · Hebrew, Aramaic, Greek · roughly 1,000 years of composition · no single author, no single editor, no original title page.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* How It Was Assembled, p. 003; Empire Says, p. 191.

HOW IT WAS ASSEMBLED

No angel delivered a table of contents. The collection you can buy in an airport was assembled slowly, by committees and customs and arguments, over centuries, and the process left visible seams that are worth knowing about because your Empire will be running the same process on purpose.

On the Hebrew side, the Torah settled first and earliest, then the prophetic books, then a looser third category of writings that stayed unsettled for a long while. Some books nearly did not make it. Esther was disputed partly because God is never mentioned in it. Song of Songs was disputed because it is frankly erotic and required a great deal of allegorising to become respectable. Ecclesiastes was disputed because it is bleak enough to sound faithless. The pattern is not random: the books that struggled were the ones hardest to use as instruction.

On the Christian side the process was messier and more political. For the first few centuries there was no fixed New Testament, only a widening pool of gospels, letters and apocalypses circulating unevenly between cities. Lists were proposed, contested, revised. The four gospels that won were not the only four written, and Revelation barely survived the cut in some quarters while other apocalypses were dropped entirely. By the time an emperor was sponsoring bishops the shortlist was largely fixed, but the fixing had human fingerprints all over it.

Two things follow that matter enormously for TKC. First, canonisation is an act of power, and it is always performed by whoever currently has the authority to convene the meeting. Second, once a canon is closed, the arguing does not stop, it simply moves — out of the question of *which books* and into the question of *which verses matter*. Dominion inherits a closed canon and therefore does all of its work at the level of emphasis, translation, lectionary and commentary. That is a quieter kind of editing, and a much harder one to catch.

> WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH THIS
>
> Never touch the canon. Touch the calendar. Decide which passages are read in public worship, which are reserved for clergy, which appear in the schoolbooks, and which are simply never printed in the cheap edition given to the provinces.

BOOKS THAT NEARLY LOST

Esther · Song of Songs · Ecclesiastes · Jude · Revelation · Hebrews · 2 Peter

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Religious Institutions, p. 205; Passages Dominion Would Suppress, p. 220.

THE SHAPE OF THE OLD TESTAMENT

Thirty-nine books, and the plot beneath all of them is land: getting it, losing it, and being ruled by somebody else's empire on it. Learn the six movements below and you will always know roughly where you are standing, which is most of what reading well requires.

TORAH *Genesis–Deuteronomy*	Origins, a family, slavery, escape, and a law delivered in a desert to a people who do not yet have a country. Everything later in the collection quotes or argues with these five books, and every empire in your novel's tradition will claim to be enforcing them.
CONQUEST & JUDGES *Joshua–Ruth*	Taking the land, then failing to hold it together. Judges is the most brutal stretch in the collection and ends with a sentence that functions as a political thesis: everyone did as they saw fit, because there was no king. Ruth answers it quietly with a foreigner.
MONARCHY *Samuel–Chronicles*	A people demand a king, are explicitly warned what a king will cost them, and get one anyway. What follows is dynasty, temple, civil war, and a long record of succession by murder. Chronicles retells the same events with the embarrassing parts managed — the first act of imperial editing in the book itself.
EXILE & RETURN *Ezra–Esther*	The state is destroyed, the population deported, and the survivors must work out how to be a people without a country. Then a partial return, a rebuilt wall, a purity crisis about foreign wives, and a queen in a foreign court who never once mentions God.
WISDOM & POETRY *Job–Song of Songs*	The interior life of the tradition, and the place where it argues with itself most openly: a man on an ash heap accusing God of injustice, a hymnbook that includes rage, a book of orderly proverbs, a book that says order is vapour, and a love poem nobody has ever quite managed to sanitise.
PROPHETS *Isaiah–Malachi*	Not fortune-tellers. Political speech, mostly addressed to the powerful, mostly about the treatment of the poor, the widow, the immigrant and the worker, and mostly furious. This is the section every empire is most careful about, and the one your resistance will quote.

CONTESTED

Whether the conquest narratives record history, later national myth, or theology in narrative dress is genuinely disputed. Your Empire will read them as precedent for holy war; your dissidents as the propaganda of a small kingdom explaining itself.

THE SHAPE OF THE NEW TESTAMENT

Twenty-seven documents, all written inside the Roman Empire by members of a movement with no political power whatsoever, most of them within about seventy years of a public execution. That situation shapes everything, including the parts your Empire will most want to use.

GOSPELS *Matthew–John*	Four accounts of one life, and they do not match, which is the most useful thing about them. Mark is urgent and bleak, Matthew is arguing that this is the fulfilment of the Law, Luke keeps putting women and poor people in the frame, and John is doing theology at high altitude. Read them side by side and you are watching four communities decide what mattered.
ACTS *the movement spreads*	A small, illegal, property-sharing sect argues its way across the Mediterranean, mostly in rented rooms and courtrooms. Worth reading closely for how a movement without institutions makes decisions, and who ends up hosting it: repeatedly, women with houses.
PAUL'S LETTERS *Romans–Philemon*	Occasional correspondence, not a systematic theology, and this single fact undoes half of what gets built on them. Each letter is one side of a conversation with a specific congregation in a specific crisis. When a verse is lifted out of that, you are quoting an answer while suppressing the question.
GENERAL LETTERS *Hebrews–Jude*	Written to scattered communities under pressure. James is blunt about the rich in a way no comfortable institution enjoys reading aloud, and the letters attributed to Peter are largely about how to live faithfully while powerless — a genre your Empire cannot use and your rebels can.
REVELATION *apocalyptic*	Resistance literature in code, written for people being persecuted by an empire that called itself divine. The beast is a state, the whore is a capital city, and the whole book is a claim that Rome will not last. Read it as prophecy of the far future and you lose the plot; read it as a banned pamphlet and it becomes the most politically dangerous text in the collection.

> THE CENTRAL IRONY FOR TKC
>
> Every document here was written by people with no power, about a man the state executed, for readers the state despised. Dominion runs its theology on literature composed by the losing side — the raw material for its own undoing is bound into the volume it hands out at induction.

THE GENRES, AND WHY THEY MATTER

Reading a poem as a statute is the single most common way this book gets weaponised, and it is almost always deliberate. A curse is not a command. A lament is not a doctrine. A proverb is a generalisation that its own collection elsewhere contradicts. Learn to name what you are holding before you decide what it obliges anyone to do.

LAW	Binding instruction for a specific covenant community, embedded in a specific economy. Asks: who is this addressed to, and what did it replace?
NARRATIVE	Story, and stories describe far more than they endorse. The Bible reports polygamy, slavery and massacre without approving them; conflating the two is a choice.
POETRY	Compressed, figurative, built on parallel lines. Reads emotion, not policy. Half the atrocities justified from scripture come from flattening a metaphor.
WISDOM	Observed patterns offered as advice, deliberately in tension across books. Proverbs and Ecclesiastes are supposed to be read against each other.
PROPHECY	Public political address, usually to rulers, usually conditional: change this or the consequence follows. Rarely about the distant future.
LETTER	One half of a private correspondence about a local crisis. Every general rule you extract has a specific quarrel behind it.
GOSPEL	Biography with an argument. Each writer selects, orders and shapes to persuade a particular community of something.
APOCALYPTIC	Coded resistance writing for the persecuted. Symbols stand for present empires, not future technologies.

THE GENRE TEST ⌖

Before a character quotes anything at anyone: what genre is this, who was it addressed to, and what does the speaker gain by treating it as a rule?

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* How to Read a Passage, p. 008.

TRANSLATION, AND WHICH ONE TO TRUST

Every translation is an argument. Somebody had to decide whether a Greek word describing a woman in a congregation means *servant* or *deacon*, whether an instruction is addressed to wives or to all believers reciprocally, whether a term for a household head implies ownership, and whether an ambiguous phrase gets resolved toward hierarchy or toward mutuality. These are not neutral calls, and the committees that make them have theological commitments, denominational funders, and intended markets.

For your purposes the practical method is simple: read any passage that matters in at least two translations from different traditions, and when they diverge, stop, because the divergence is the interesting part. That gap is exactly where Dominion lives. An empire that controls the official edition does not need to lie; it only needs to keep choosing the harder-edged rendering, generation after generation, until the softer reading sounds like modern invention.

It is worth knowing that translations sit on a spectrum. Some aim at word-for-word fidelity and read stiffly. Some aim at thought-for-thought clarity and smooth over difficulty. Some are frank paraphrases with a strong voice. None of these is dishonest by definition, but the smoother the English, the more interpretive decisions have already been made for you and hidden.

One more thing, and it belongs in the novel. Chapters and verses are not original. They were added centuries later for citation, and they have quietly made the whole book quotable in fragments — which is precisely the format a state needs for slogans, wall inscriptions, and school recitation. The verse is the unit of propaganda; the paragraph is the unit of meaning.

> DOMINION'S EDITION
>
> Decide early what the Empire's authorised text is, who is permitted to own an unauthorised one, what has been footnoted into harmlessness, and which single word in the household passages the whole Ministry's authority rests on. A translation controversy is a perfectly good inciting incident.

METHOD

Two translations minimum, from different traditions. Note every divergence. The gap is the material.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Vocabulary for a Novelist, p. 256.

HOW TO READ A PASSAGE IN CONTEXT

Eight questions, in this order, every time. Run them and you will be reading better than most people who quote this book professionally, and you will be able to write clergy who are genuinely sophisticated rather than merely sinister.

I	WHAT KIND OF TEXT	Name the genre before anything else. Law, story, poem, letter, oracle, apocalypse. This decides what kind of claim it can even make.
II	WHO IS SPEAKING	The narrator, a character, God quoted by a character, an opponent being paraphrased, or a proverb the author is about to demolish. Job's friends get pages of confident theology that the book itself rejects.
III	TO WHOM	A named congregation, a king, a nation, an enslaved population, a household. Instructions to the powerful read very differently when redirected at the powerless, and that redirection is the most common abuse there is.
IV	WHAT COMES BEFORE	Read the paragraph on either side, then the chapter, then skim the whole book's argument. A verse used as a wall inscription almost always has a sentence beside it that complicates it.
V	WHAT WORLD	The economy, the legal status of women and slaves, who owned land, what an honour culture punished. Not to excuse the text, but to see what it was arguing with — sometimes it is more radical than its context, sometimes far less.
VI	WHAT THE WORDS DO	Check a second translation on any word carrying weight. If two respectable versions disagree, you have found a decision, not a fact.
VII	WHO GAINS	Ask it of the passage and of every reading of it, including the ones you find sympathetic. Interpretations have beneficiaries.
VIII	WHAT IT COSTS	Who has to absorb the consequence if this reading is enforced. That answer usually names the character in your novel who lives inside the doctrine.

A WORKED EXAMPLE

THE HOUSEHOLD VERSE

Take the passage every scriptural empire in history has built its household law on: the instruction to wives in the letter to Ephesus. Run the eight questions and watch how much of the standard use depends on stopping at question one.

> *"Wives, submit to your husbands" — the fragment as it appears on a wall, in a schoolbook, in a wedding rite, and in every Ministry pamphlet.*
>
> EPHESIANS 5.22, QUOTED ALONE

GENRE	A letter. Occasional correspondence to one congregation, not statute.
THE SENTENCE BEFORE	An instruction to the entire assembly to submit to one another. Grammatically, the wives clause hangs off it — in the earliest Greek it does not even carry its own verb. Cut that line and you convert a mutual instruction into a one-way command.
THE PASSAGE AFTER	Roughly three times as long, addressed to husbands, and demanding self-sacrifice to the point of death. The asymmetry runs the opposite way to the one usually preached.
THE WORLD	Roman household codes were a standard literary form, and they were far harsher. Read against its own context the passage is a modification of an existing hierarchy, not the invention of one — which is exactly the fact an empire must suppress to present it as timeless.
THE WORDS	The verb rendered *submit* is voluntary in form, not imperative in the way English suggests, and the word for *head* carries a contested range that translators resolve according to conviction.
WHO GAINS	Whoever is permitted to quote the fragment and forbidden to read the frame. That permission is an administrative decision, and administrative decisions have names attached.

WHAT DOMINION DOES

Prints the fragment, omits the mutual line, shortens the husbands' passage in the provincial edition, and sets the whole thing to music so it is learned by children before it is ever read.

WHAT THIS GIVES TKC

A scene where a character reads the missing line for the first time. Not a revelation about God — a revelation about editing, which is worse, because it means somebody chose.

CONTESTED READINGS

These are the fault lines. Each has been argued in good faith for centuries by people who know the languages better than either of us will, and no amount of reading settles them. For the novel they are gifts: a doctrine Dominion has closed is a doctrine somewhere in the Empire is still quietly open, and every one of these is a possible character conflict rather than a research problem.

HEADSHIP

Whether the household passages establish a permanent order of authority or address a specific culture's arrangements. Both readings have long pedigrees and neither is fringe.

WOMEN SPEAKING

One letter silences women in assembly; the same author greets women running congregations and names one an apostle. Reconciling that is a live dispute, not a solved one.

SLAVERY

Whether the letters accommodate an existing institution, quietly undermine it, or endorse it. Both sides of the historical abolition fight quoted scripture fluently, and that fact belongs in your Empire.

DIVINE VIOLENCE

Whether the conquest commands are historical, rhetorical, or a later people's theology of their own past. Everything about holy war in your novel rests on which answer Dominion teaches.

OBEDIENCE TO RULERS

One passage says authorities are appointed by God; the same collection is full of prophets defying kings and apostles refusing magistrates. Which one is the rule and which the exception has never been settled, and empires have always known which they prefer.

WEALTH

Whether prosperity signals blessing or is itself the danger. Deuteronomy and the prophets pull hard in opposite directions, and a ruling class will always find the first easier to preach.

PURITY & THE BODY

Which purity laws were ritual, which moral, which permanently binding, and who gets to decide. The line drawn here determines what your Empire can regulate about a woman's body and call it faith.

THE END OF THINGS

Whether apocalyptic language describes a coming event, a present spiritual reality, or a coded verdict on a particular empire. A state that teaches the first can promise anything and deliver nothing.

WHICH SIDE DOES DOMINION TEACH, AND WHO IN MY NOVEL DISAGREES *write here*

WHAT THE BIBLE ACTUALLY IS

A library, not a book. Sixty-six documents in the Protestant collection this companion starts from, written across roughly a thousand years, in three languages, by people who did not know they were contributing to the same volume — and who in several cases were arguing with each other.

WHICH BIBLE THIS COMPANION USES, AND WHY THAT SENTENCE IS NECESSARY INFORMATION

We begin with the sixty-six-book Protestant canon, because that is the Bible in the room where you were raised and the Bible Dominion would have inherited. It is not the only Bible. Jewish tradition holds twenty-four books in three divisions and does not arrange them as an Old Testament. Catholic Bibles include the deuterocanonical books. Orthodox collections include those and more, and differ among themselves. The Ethiopian Orthodox canon is larger than any of them. None of this is a technicality — the shape of the collection is itself an argument about what scripture is for.

IT DOES NOT SPEAK IN ONE HUMAN VOICE

This is the correction that matters most for a novelist. The Bible contains many voices — priestly and prophetic, royal and exilic, ecstatic and administrative — in different genres, from different centuries, addressing different crises. When a character quotes scripture as though it has a single settled opinion, that character is making a choice, and the choice is worth writing about.

THE INTERNAL CONVERSATIONS CONTESTED

Read these as thematic tensions and interpretive conversations, not as authors calling each other liars.

THE TENSION	WHAT IS ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE
Deuteronomy & Job	Deuteronomic theology links covenant faithfulness to flourishing. Job does not declare that a lie; it takes a righteous sufferer and lets his comforters make the simple version of the argument until it collapses. The dispute is over retributive theology applied as a rule.
Ezra & Ruth	Ezra–Nehemiah records the dissolution of foreign marriages as restoration policy. Ruth makes a Moabite woman the great-grandmother of David. Two answers to the same post-exilic question about boundaries and belonging.
Proverbs & Ecclesiastes	Proverbs teaches that wisdom is learnable and generally pays. Ecclesiastes watches the same world and reports that the pattern does not hold. Both are wisdom literature; they simply disagree about how reliable wisdom is.
Power & prophecy	Court histories narrate kingship from inside the institution. The prophets address the same monarchies from outside, indicting how power treats the poor, the widow, the immigrant, and the worker — among other concerns, including idolatry, false worship, and international politics.

> **THE COMPANION'S WORKING LENS — NOT A DEFINITION OF CANON**
>
> A canon is not simply what a religion believes; it is the collection a community has received, used, and authorized over time. This companion reads canon formation with attention to who held the authority to decide — a recurring strategy of religious power, and the reason Dominion cares which books its citizens own.

FOUR COLLECTIONS

Same core, different edges, different order — and the order is an argument. Where a collection ends tells you what it thinks the story is about.

COLLECTION	BOOKS	HOW IT IS ARRANGED	WHERE IT ENDS, AND WHY THAT MATTERS
Tanakh Jewish	24	Torah, Nevi'im (Prophets), Ketuvim (Writings). Not an "Old" Testament — a complete scripture in its own right.	Chronicles, ending with the call to go up and rebuild. The story closes on return and restoration.
Protestant	66	39 Old Testament, 28 New. Same Hebrew books as the Tanakh, counted and ordered differently, with the Prophets moved to the end.	Malachi, then Revelation. The Hebrew scriptures end on unfulfilled prophecy, which frames them as prologue.
Catholic	73	Adds the deuterocanonical books — Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, 1–2 Maccabees, and additions to Daniel and Esther.	Includes the Maccabean revolt: armed resistance to an empire that outlawed the practice of the faith.
Orthodox	76+	Varies by communion. Greek, Slavonic, Ethiopian, and other traditions differ from one another as well as from Rome.	There is no single answer, which is itself the useful fact: canon has never been globally uniform.

THE FOUR WORDS THAT ARE NOT SYNONYMS

Canon — which books are in. **Translation** — which words render them. **Edition** — which notes, headings, and apparatus surround them. **Lectionary** — which passages get read aloud, and when. An empire that cannot change the canon can still change the last three, and the last one is the cheapest.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH THIS PAGE DOMINION

Never print it. A citizen who knows there are four collections knows there was a decision, and a citizen who knows there was a decision asks who made it. The Empire's Bible has to feel like weather rather than legislation.

WHICH COLLECTION IS THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL BIBLE, AND WHAT IT LEAVES OUT ON PURPOSE YOURS

WHAT YOU BROUGHT TO IT

Answer these before the research goes any further. Not a test — a baseline, so that later discoveries can be measured against something real instead of against a memory that has quietly revised itself.

WHAT I THOUGHT THE BIBLE WAS BEFORE THIS PAGE

WHICH CANON OR EDITION I GREW UP AROUND — TRANSLATION, COVER, WHOSE COPY IT WAS

WHAT I WAS NEVER TOLD ABOUT HOW IT IS ORGANIZED

WHAT THIS CHANGES ABOUT DOMINION'S OFFICIAL BIBLE

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R] DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

RUN ONE TENSION YOURSELF

Take one of the four conversations from the opening page — or find your own — and work it. The point is not to resolve it. The point is to be able to say precisely what is in dispute, which is the skill this whole section exists to build.

THE TENSION I AM WORKING

PASSAGES ON EACH SIDE

WHAT IS ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE — IN ONE SENTENCE, WITHOUT TAKING A SIDE

WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING

WHICH SIDE DOMINION PRINTS — AND WHICH SIDE IT LETS PEOPLE SING

WHICH CHARACTER IS ON WHICH SIDE, AND WHETHER SHE KNOWS THERE IS A SIDE

> *Nothing written on this page is canon until it is logged. Discovery is discovery; possibility is not canon.*

HOW IT WAS ASSEMBLED

There was never a room where the Bible was decided. That is the single most useful thing to know about it, and the hardest thing to hold onto — because a room would be easier to write about, and every empire in the book would prefer you believed in one.

USE CAME FIRST, RECOGNITION CAME SECOND INFORMATION

Communities read, copied, argued over, and prayed with these texts for generations before anyone published a list. Lists, when they came, mostly ratified habits already formed — and the habits were local. A congregation in Alexandria and one in Carthage could disagree about a book for a century without either considering itself in schism.

FOUR GOSPELS, AND WHAT THAT ACTUALLY MEANS

Other gospels existed and circulated. The four in the canon are the four that were most widely read across the most communities, earliest, and were treated as apostolic in origin — and Irenaeus was arguing for exactly four by the late second century, which tells you the number was contested enough to need an argument. Calling them the gospels that "won" makes it sound like a vote. It was closer to consensus hardening around what was already in use, with the theological arguments running alongside rather than deciding it in one stroke.

WHO ACTUALLY HELD THE AUTHORITY CONTESTED

Bishops wrote lists. Councils confirmed regional practice more often than they created it. Emperors funded copies, convened meetings, and made certain outcomes safer to hold than others — Constantine's involvement at Nicaea was real, and Nicaea was not about the canon. Local congregational use was the slow current under all of it. The honest sentence is that canon formation was a long negotiation among all four, and the balance shifted by century and region.

THE CLAIM WORTH KEEPING, STATED CAREFULLY

Not *canonization is always performed by whoever can convene the meeting* — too absolute, and it credits meetings with more than they did. What holds: the people who could convene, fund, copy, and distribute had disproportionate influence over which texts stayed in circulation, and circulation is most of what canon means in practice.

> ### WHY THIS SEQUENCE IS SIX PAGES INSTEAD OF ONE
>
> Because a single page can only make the compressed version, and the compressed version is the propaganda version. Dominion's account of its own Bible will be exactly one page long.

TORAH, PROPHETS, WRITINGS

Three divisions, settling at different times. The order of settling is itself information: the most authoritative material stabilized first, and the edges were still being discussed centuries later.

DIVISION	ROUGHLY WHEN	WHAT WAS HAPPENING
Torah	by the Persian period	Functioning as authoritative law for the restored community. Public reading is already an institution — Nehemiah 8 shows the practice, and the practice is the point.
Prophets	later, gradually	Former and Latter Prophets circulating as a recognized body. By the second century BCE a writer can refer to the law and the prophets as a known pairing.
Writings	latest to settle	The loose end. Psalms and Proverbs uncontroversial; Esther, Ecclesiastes, and Song of Songs discussed well into the rabbinic period.
Septuagint	3rd c. BCE onward	Greek translation for Greek-speaking Jewish communities, with a wider and looser collection. This is the Bible most New Testament writers quote — which is why the Christian Old Testament inherits a different shape.

EARLY CHRISTIAN USE OF JEWISH SCRIPTURE

The first Christians had no New Testament. They had Israel's scriptures, read as testimony about what had just happened to them — which is a reading strategy, not a neutral inheritance. Every appeal to prophecy in the Gospels is that strategy working in public.

THE DEAD SEA SCROLLS, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

A library hidden by a Jewish community and recovered in the twentieth century, containing biblical manuscripts a thousand years older than the previously standard Hebrew texts. They show a text remarkably stable in most places and genuinely variable in others — which is the single best correction to the idea that the Hebrew Bible either never changed or was rewritten wholesale.

WHICH DIVISION DOMINION WOULD TEACH FIRST TO CHILDREN, AND WHICH IT WOULD SAVE FOR CLERGY

YOURS

A THOUSAND YEARS OF DECIDING

Approximate throughout, and contested in places — dates in this field are arguments, not measurements. What the shape shows: no single moment, and a very long tail.

WHEN	WHAT MOVED
c. 5th c. BCE	Torah functioning as authoritative law in the restored Judean community.
c. 3rd–1st c. BCE	Septuagint translated and expanded in Alexandria. Prophets recognized as a body. Wisdom and apocalyptic writing flourishing.
c. 50–60 CE	Paul's letters written — the earliest New Testament documents, composed as occasional correspondence to specific congregations, decades before any Gospel.
c. 70–100 CE	The Gospels written, after the destruction of the Temple. Composition order is not canonical order, and the gap matters: the Gospels are written into a world where the institution at the center of the story is already rubble.
2nd century	Marcion publishes a deliberately reduced collection; the pushback sharpens everyone's sense that the boundary matters. Irenaeus argues for four Gospels. The Muratorian fragment lists much of what becomes the New Testament — and omits some of it.
3rd–4th century	Eusebius sorts books into accepted, disputed, and rejected — a working scholar's triage, not a verdict. Athanasius issues a list in 367 CE matching the twenty-seven-book New Testament.
late 4th century	Regional councils in North Africa affirm lists close to the current one. Jerome produces the Latin Vulgate and flags the books he considers secondary — a distinction Rome does not adopt.
Middle Ages	Stable practice in the West with the wider collection in use; Eastern churches settle differently and not uniformly. Chapter divisions added in the thirteenth century.
16th century	Reformers reorder the Old Testament and separate or drop the deuterocanonical books; Trent affirms them. Verse numbering added mid-century. Printing makes a household Bible possible for the first time — and makes a standardized one enforceable.
19th–20th c.	Older manuscripts recovered, critical editions built, and translations proliferate. The text you can buy today rests on more evidence than any previous century had.

THE ONES THEY ARGUED ABOUT

The tempting theory is that the contested books were the ones hardest to preach from. It is too tidy — the recorded objections are usually about authorship, provenance, or specific content, and each book has its own reason. Read the right-hand column as the reasons actually given, not as a single pattern.

BOOK	STATUS	WHAT THE OBJECTION ACTUALLY WAS
Esther	discussed	The Hebrew text never names God. Its festival, Purim, is not in the Torah. Both were raised in rabbinic discussion; it was received regardless, and the Greek version supplies explicitly religious material the Hebrew lacks.
Song of Songs	discussed	Explicit love poetry with no overt theology. Allegorical reading — God and Israel, Christ and the church — became the standard defense, and remains a reading rather than a settled fact about the text's origin.
Ecclesiastes	discussed	Its conclusions sit awkwardly against the rest of the wisdom tradition. The closing verses read to many scholars as a later frame added to make the book usable.
Hebrews	disputed	Anonymous. Its acceptance in the West lagged behind the East precisely because Pauline authorship could not be established — and nearly all scholars now consider it not Paul's.
James	disputed	Slow to circulate widely, and later a Reformation flashpoint over faith and works. Luther ranked it below others; it stayed in.
2 Peter	disputed	The most doubted book in the New Testament in antiquity, on grounds of style and attribution. Its authorship remains a live scholarly question rather than a settled one.
Jude	disputed	Quotes 1 Enoch, a book outside the canon it ended up inside. That citation was the recorded difficulty.
Revelation	disputed	Widely accepted in the West, long resisted in the Greek East over authorship and over its use by groups predicting an imminent end. It is still absent from the Eastern lectionary — accepted as scripture, not read aloud in the liturgy.

THE ONE IN THE LAST ROW IS THE ONE TO STEAL DOMINION

A book can be fully canonical and never read aloud. That is a real historical arrangement, not an invention — and it is the most elegant instrument on this page. The Empire never has to ban anything.

WHICH BOOKS ARE IN DOMINION'S BIBLE AND NEVER IN ITS LECTIONARY YOURS

SIX INSTRUMENTS

The Empire does not need to change a word of the canon. Everything below is documented practice somewhere in history, and none of it requires editing scripture. Rank them by what Dominion would reach for first.

I · THE CALENDAR RANK _____

Which feasts exist, which are civic, which are quietly dropped. A calendar decides what a population rehearses annually — and a holiday nobody keeps is a doctrine nobody remembers.

II · THE PUBLIC READINGS RANK _____

The lectionary. Cheapest and strongest instrument on the page: for most citizens, scripture *is* what gets read aloud. The rest of the book is technically available and functionally silent.

III · CLERGY ACCESS RANK _____

Who is trained, in what, and who is permitted to teach it. Control the seminary and you do not have to control the pulpit — Prelate Huldah's assessment team is this instrument with a person's name on it.

IV · THE SCHOOLBOOKS RANK _____

Which stories children learn as stories, and in which order. The slowest instrument and the only one that compounds — a generation taught one shape of the book will hear anything else as novelty.

V · PROVINCIAL EDITIONS RANK _____

Same canon, different apparatus, Dominion by Dominion. Headings, footnotes, cross-references, and study notes do most of the interpretive work in any Bible a citizen actually owns — and none of it is scripture.

VI · COMMENTARY & EMPHASIS RANK _____

What the Broadcast says a passage means, repeated until the gloss is inseparable from the verse. The only instrument that works retroactively on people who already own the book.

WHICH INSTRUMENT DOMINION USED FIRST, HISTORICALLY — AND WHICH ONE IT IS STILL AFRAID TO USE

DOMINION'S OWN ACCOUNT

Write the Empire's version of this sequence — one page, the way a Dominion schoolbook would tell it. Then write what it left out. The gap between the two is a doctrine, and doctrines have authors.

THE EMPIRE'S ACCOUNT OF HOW ITS BIBLE CAME TO BE — IN THE VOICE OF A SCHOOLBOOK

WHAT IT LEAVES OUT, AND WHO WOULD BE DANGEROUS IF THEY KNEW IT

WHICH CHARACTER FINDS THE GAP FIRST, AND IN WHAT DOCUMENT

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R] DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

EIGHT GENRES

Genre is not decoration. It determines what a passage is capable of establishing — and misreading it is the most common way a sincere reader arrives at a confident wrong answer.

GENRE	WHAT IT IS TRYING TO DO	WHAT IT CANNOT ESTABLISH
Law	Order a community's obligations — ritual, civil, and moral, usually undifferentiated.	Universal timeless policy. Legal codes address a specific society's cases.
Narrative	Tell what happened, shaped for a purpose. Frequently reports behavior without endorsing it.	Approval. A story about polygamy is not an argument for it.
Poetry	Make something felt. Works by image, parallelism, and intensification.	Doctrine, from a metaphor read literally.
Wisdom	Teach how the world generally works, and — in Job and Ecclesiastes — how often it does not.	Promises. A proverb is a pattern, not a guarantee.
Prophecy	Deliver a message on behalf of God to a specific people at a specific moment — indictment, warning, consolation, and sometimes prediction. Political and social judgment are major functions, not the only ones; worship, idolatry, and the character of God run throughout.	A calendar. Most prophetic speech addresses its own audience's present, though some texts do look forward — and later communities read them forward too.
Gospel	Present a life so that the hearer will reckon with it. Ancient biography with a purpose, not neutral reportage.	A transcript. Selection and arrangement are part of the form.
Letter	Address a live situation in a named community — while often arguing theology at length in the process.	Context-free rules. You are reading one side of a conversation.
Apocalyptic	Reveal what is really happening behind visible power, in symbol, to people who cannot say it plainly.	Technology forecasts. Its symbols were legible to its first audience; later readings exist and are readings.

WHAT GENRE ERROR ACTUALLY COSTS

Flattening a metaphor into a rule, or a narrative into an endorsement, has produced real harm and continues to — and it is one mechanism among several, alongside deliberate misuse, selective quotation, and institutional interest. It is worth naming precisely rather than credited with everything.

FORMS INSIDE THE FORMS

Eight genres is the map. These are the units a passage is actually built from, and naming the unit is usually enough to settle what it can be used for.

Genealogy	A claim about belonging and legitimacy. Who is included is the argument — Matthew's four women are the whole point of Matthew's list.
Lament	Structured complaint, often addressed to God and often unresolved. Its presence in the canon means protest is a sanctioned form of speech.
Hymn	Communal praise, often older than the book it sits in. Frequently quoted material — which means it was already familiar.
Proverb	A compressed observation. Reliable as a pattern, dangerous as a promise, and lethal as a rebuke to someone suffering.
Parable	A story built to reposition the hearer. Usually has one hinge; allegorizing every detail is how it gets defused.
Oracle	A delivered message with a named addressee, often a foreign nation. Reading one addressed to Babylon as addressed to you is a category error with a long history.
Legal code	Case law with penalties attached, comparable to other ancient Near Eastern codes. Comparison is where the distinctive parts show.
Court history	Institutional record written near power. Ask who commissioned it and what it does not mention.

THE GENRE TEST — RUN IT BEFORE QUOTING ANYTHING

1. What kind of writing is this?

2. What is this kind of writing for?

3. What can it establish?

4. What is it incapable of establishing?

5. Am I using it for the thing it can do?

6. If not — is the misuse mine, or my character's?

THE GENRE DOMINION MISREADS ON PURPOSE, AND THE ONE IT MISREADS SINCERELY

GENRE

One blank spread per genre.
Photocopy before filling.

WHAT THIS GENRE IS

WHAT IT IS TRYING TO DO

WHAT IT CAN ESTABLISH

WHAT IT CANNOT

THREE EXAMPLES, WITH REFERENCES

THE PASSAGE I AM PRACTICING ON

WHAT THE EMPIRE DOES WITH IT

HOW DOMINION COULD MISUSE THIS GENRE — THE SPECIFIC MECHANISM

WHO IN THE EMPIRE BENEFITS, AND WHO PAYS

WHICH CHARACTER READS THIS GENRE CORRECTLY, AND WHAT IT COSTS HER

MY QUESTIONS ABOUT THIS GENRE

WHAT I NEED TO RESEARCH BEFORE I WRITE THIS INTO A SCENE

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R] DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

SIX MOVEMENTS

An orientation, not a summary. The collection is not arranged as a single story, and the movements below overlap, double back, and in places contradict each other about what happened.

MOVEMENT	WHAT IT IS ABOUT	THE QUESTION IT LEAVES OPEN
Beginnings Genesis 1–11	Creation, rupture, flood, and the scattering of peoples. Two creation accounts sit side by side without being reconciled.	Whether human power over others is part of the design or part of the damage.
The families Genesis 12–50	Promise attached to one household and carried through four generations of deception, infertility, favoritism, and migration.	Why the promise keeps passing through the person who should not have received it.
Exodus & law Exodus–Deuteronomy	Liberation from imperial forced labor, then forty years of learning to be a people, then a legal code delivered before the land is entered.	Whether a people freed from empire can legislate without reproducing it.
Land & kings Joshua–Kings	Settlement, tribal instability, the demand for a monarchy, David's house, division into two kingdoms, and the slow loss of both.	Whether monarchy was a concession, a failure, or the plan.
Exile & return Ezra, Neh., Chron.	Deportation, survival under foreign rule, partial return, rebuilding, and a fierce argument about who belongs to the restored community.	Who counts, who is dissolved out of the community, and who gets to write the record.
Wisdom & prophecy across the collection	Two bodies of material that comment on all of the above — one asking how to live well, one indicting how power actually behaves.	Whether either one ever changed anything.

THIS COMPANION'S LENS — DECLARED, NOT NEUTRAL

Land runs through most of these movements — possession, loss, return, and who is permitted to hold it. That is a genuine and recurring concern of the collection, and reading the whole Old Testament as fundamentally *about* land is this companion's working lens, chosen because Dominion is a land empire. It is not a neutral description of the material.

WHERE THE STORY STOPS

Same books, two sequences, two different endings — and therefore two different claims about what the collection is doing.

TANAKH ORDER

Torah → Prophets → Writings, closing with Chronicles and Cyrus's decree to go up and rebuild.

Ends on *return*. The arc is instruction, then the record of failing it, then the literature of living with that — and the last word is permission to go home.

CHRISTIAN OLD TESTAMENT ORDER

Law → history → poetry → prophets, closing with Malachi and a promise of one who is coming.

Ends on *anticipation*. The same books, resequenced so the collection reads as unfinished — which is what makes a New Testament feel like a continuation rather than an addition.

A ROUGH HISTORICAL SPINE INFORMATION

c. 1000 BCE	The united monarchy of the biblical narrative — David and Solomon. Archaeological reconstruction of its scale is actively debated.
c. 930 BCE	Division into Israel in the north and Judah in the south. Two kingdoms, two records, one collection.
722 BCE	Assyria destroys the northern kingdom. Deportation and dispersal — the first great loss.
587/586 BCE	Babylon destroys Jerusalem and the Temple; the elite are deported. Much of the collection is written, edited, or compiled in the shadow of this.
539 BCE	Persia takes Babylon; return is permitted. Restoration is partial, contested, and administered under imperial authority.
332–63 BCE	Greek then Roman rule. Apocalyptic literature develops under occupation, which is the setting that produces it.

WHICH ORDERING DOMINION PRINTS, AND WHAT ENDING IT NEEDS ITS CITIZENS TO EXPECT YOURS

SAY IT MORE CAREFULLY

Four claims worth keeping, restated so they survive contact with someone who knows the material. The memorable version is in the left column and the defensible version is on the right, and the difference between them is the whole discipline of this companion.

THE MEMORABLE VERSION	WHAT IS ACTUALLY DEFENSIBLE
Judges says there was no king, so the book wants one.	The refrain — no king in Israel, everyone doing as they saw fit — sits inside a collection that is genuinely divided about monarchy. Samuel records the demand for a king as a rejection of divine rule and lists exactly what a king will take. Judges names the cost of no central authority; it does not settle the argument, and the collection keeps having it.
Ruth answers it quietly.	An interpretation, and a good one — a Moabite woman's loyalty placed in the genealogy of David reads as a counterargument to exclusion. Mark it as a reading. The book does not announce itself as a rebuttal, and dating it precisely enough to prove intent is not possible.
Chronicles is the first act of imperial editing in the book itself.	Too confident. Chronicles retells Samuel–Kings with visible selection — David's worst material largely absent, Temple and worship foregrounded — which makes it an excellent case study in how a community re-narrates its own past for present purposes. Calling it the *first* such act, or specifically imperial, overstates what can be shown.
The prophets are about how power treats the poor.	They are substantially about that, and reducing them to it loses most of the material. The prophetic books also address idolatry and false worship, international politics and alliances, the fate of neighboring nations, ritual integrity, exile and consolation, and the character of God. Keep the economic and social indictment central without letting it become the whole subject.

WHY THIS PAGE EXISTS

A character who makes the left-hand claim can be brilliant and still wrong, and that is useful. A companion that makes it is simply unreliable, and you will not be able to tell which of your own pages to trust in two years.

WHICH CHARACTER MAKES THE LEFT-COLUMN ARGUMENT, AND WHO CORRECTS HER

NINE THREADS

One line each, in your own words — what the collection actually does with it, not what you were taught it does.

LAND

LAW

MONARCHY

EXILE

WOMEN

COVENANT

EMPIRE

THE TEMPLE

WHO WRITES THE RECORD

WHICH MOVEMENTS ARE TKC

Not every movement belongs in the novel. Mark the ones that do, and be specific about what they are doing there — a movement you cannot assign a job to is research, not material.

MOVEMENT	IN TKC?	DOING WHAT, AND FOR WHOM
Beginnings		
The families		
Exodus & law		
Land & kings		
Exile & return		
Wisdom & prophecy		

THE ONE MOVEMENT DOMINION IS BUILT ON WITHOUT SAYING SO

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND ABOUT THIS COLLECTION

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R] DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

TWENTY-SEVEN DOCUMENTS

Written across roughly a century by a movement inside the Roman Empire that had no state power and no established imperial standing — though it was not powerless in every sense, and its social position varied considerably by city, decade, and class.

THE FIVE KINDS OF DOCUMENT INFORMATION

Gospels · 4	Narrative accounts of Jesus, written decades after the events, each for a particular community with particular concerns.
Acts · 1	The movement's spread from Jerusalem outward, written by the author of Luke as the second volume of one work.
Pauline letters · 13	Occasional correspondence to specific congregations about specific problems — which does not prevent several of them from containing sustained theological argument. Romans is a worked case, not a memo.
General letters · 8	Hebrews and the letters attributed to James, Peter, John, and Jude — wider audiences, more varied purposes.
Apocalypse · 1	Revelation. A genre with its own conventions, not a coded newspaper.

COMPOSITION ORDER IS NOT CANONICAL ORDER

Paul's letters come first chronologically — written in the 50s, before any Gospel existed. The collection opens with the Gospels because it is arranged as a story, not as an archive. Reading it in composition order shows a movement working out what it believed before anyone had written down the life it was believing about.

THE ROMAN SETTING, WITHOUT FLATTENING IT

Occupation, client kings, taxation, crucifixion as public policy, imperial cult, and a legal status for the movement that changed by place and period — tolerated in some cities, prosecuted in others, and not systematically illegal across the empire for most of this century. Acts shows shared property in Jerusalem specifically; it is not a description of every congregation everywhere, and Paul's letters show congregations with property, patrons, and households.

> *For TKC the useful fact is not that the early movement was poor or illegal. It is that a religion born under an empire was later administered by one — and that the same texts served both.*

FOUR ACCOUNTS, ONE SUBJECT

They differ in selection, arrangement, emphasis, and detail. That is not the same as saying they do not match — and the differences are the most informative thing about them, because each one shows you what a particular community needed the story to do.

GOSPEL	c. DATE	WHAT IT EMPHASIZES	WHERE IT BEGINS
Mark	70	Urgency, secrecy, suffering. Shortest, probably earliest, and the source most scholars think Matthew and Luke worked from.	An adult at the river. No birth story at all.
Matthew	80s	Fulfillment of Israel's scriptures, teaching arranged in five great blocks, a new Moses. Written for a community deeply engaged with Jewish law.	A genealogy, with four women in it, one of them Ruth.
Luke	80s	The poor, women, outsiders, and reversal — the powerful pulled down, the hungry filled. Volume one of a two-volume work.	Two pregnancies and a song about thrones being emptied.
John	90s	Identity and glory. Long discourses, few parables, a different chronology, and its own material almost throughout.	Before creation.

WHY FOUR MATTERS FOR A NOVELIST

Because the canon preserves four versions instead of harmonizing them into one, and that decision is visible on every page. An empire that wanted a single official account had four to choose from and could not quietly reduce them — so it did the next best thing, which is decide which one gets read at which festival.

ACTS, AND WHAT IT IS DOING CONTESTED

A narrative of expansion from Jerusalem to Rome, shaped to show the movement's legitimacy and its reach. Where Acts and Paul's own letters describe the same events they do not always agree, and historians treat that gap as real rather than resolvable by preference.

WHICH GOSPEL DOMINION READS ALOUD MOST, AND WHICH ONE IT WOULD RATHER NOT YOURS

WHO WROTE WHAT

Authorship is a scholarly question, not a settled fact, and the distinctions below matter enormously for TKC — because the letters most often quoted about households and women's silence are the ones whose authorship is most disputed.

GROUP	SCHOLARLY VIEW	WHY IT MATTERS HERE
Undisputed Paul Rom, 1–2 Cor, Gal, Phil, 1 Thess, Phlm	Broad agreement	These are the letters where Paul names women as coworkers, deacons, and apostles, and where the theology is worked out at length rather than asserted.
Disputed Paul Eph, Col, 2 Thess	Genuinely divided	Ephesians and Colossians carry the household codes. Whether Paul wrote them changes what "the same author" can be claimed to mean.
Pastorals 1–2 Tim, Titus	Majority: later	The strictest instructions about women teaching sit here. Use "the Pauline corpus" rather than "Paul" when arguing across this boundary.
Hebrews	Anonymous	Not Paul's, by near consensus. A sustained argument about priesthood and sacrifice — directly useful to any state that runs a temple.
Attributed letters Jas, 1–2 Pet, 1–3 Jn, Jude	Varies; 2 Peter most doubted	Attributed authorship in this period is a convention with a range of practices behind it, and flatly asserting or denying it in the companion is equally unsafe.

THE ONE SENTENCE TO KEEP

The letters that constrain women most are the ones least likely to be by the man whose name is on them — and Dominion would never mention it, because the authority of the instruction rests entirely on the signature.

WHICH LETTERS DOMINION BUILT ITS HOUSEHOLD LAW ON, AND WHO IN THE EMPIRE KNOWS THE AUTHORSHIP PROBLEM

FOUR WAYS TO READ IT

All four are held by serious readers. The companion's own instinct is the first one, and it is still an interpretive framework rather than a fact about the text — keep it visibly contested, because in TKC the reading a character holds is a political position.

I · RESISTANCE LITERATURE AGAINST ROME

Written for congregations under imperial pressure, using the conventions of apocalyptic to say what could not be said plainly. Strong internal support — seven cities, imperial cult, a city on seven hills, an economy of luxury goods described with contempt. Most historical-critical scholarship works here.

II · A SEQUENCE OF FUTURE EVENTS

Read as a program of things still to come. Widely held in popular and some confessional traditions, with a long history and enormous cultural influence — and a long record of specific predictions failing, which is itself part of the material.

III · A CYCLE, NOT A TIMELINE

The visions as recurring patterns of empire, judgment, and endurance rather than a chronology. Explains the repetition — seals, trumpets, bowls covering the same ground three times — better than a sequential reading does.

IV · LITURGY AND VISION

The book as worship — hymns, thrones, incense, a heavenly assembly — meant to reorder what the hearer thinks is ultimately in charge. The Eastern churches' hesitation about reading it aloud sits oddly beside this, and both facts are true.

THE TWO IDENTIFICATIONS EVERYONE MAKES

The beast as an imperial power and the woman on the beast as a capital city are the readings the historical evidence most supports, and they are readings. Do not print them as flat facts. What is nearly unarguable is narrower and sharper: the book's targets are political and economic, and it expects its audience to recognize them.

WHICH READING IS OFFICIAL IN DOMINION — AND WHICH ONE GETS SOMEONE ARRESTED

A RELIGION BORN UNDER EMPIRE

The New Testament was written by people with no state power. Dominion is a state that runs on it. Work the distance between those two sentences — it is the engine of the entire novel.

WHICH PASSAGES BECOME EASIER TO USE ONCE YOU HOLD POWER, AND WHY

WHICH ONES BECOME EMBARRASSING, AND HOW THE EMPIRE HANDLES THEM

THE VERSE EDEN WAS TAUGHT AS COMFORT AND LATER READS AS INSTRUCTION

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R] DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

TRANSLATION AND HOW TO COMPARE IT

The old title asked which translation to trust. Wrong question — it implies one exists that never has to be checked. The goal is to understand how translation decisions get made, so you can see one being made and say what it did.

THREE LANGUAGES INFORMATION

Hebrew	Most of the Old Testament. Written originally without vowels; the vowel pointing was added centuries later by scribes preserving how the text was read aloud. A consonantal text can sometimes be vocalized more than one way, and where it can, translators choose.
Aramaic	Portions of Daniel and Ezra, and the common speech of Judea in the first century. Jesus taught in it; the Gospels record him in Greek.
Greek	The New Testament, in the common Greek of the eastern Mediterranean — not literary Greek, and not uniform. Mark's is rough; Hebrews' is polished. Translations that flatten every book to the same register lose that.

MANUSCRIPTS AND VARIANTS

No originals survive for any biblical book. What exists is thousands of copies, and they differ — overwhelmingly in spelling, word order, and obvious copying slips, occasionally in something substantive. Textual criticism is the discipline of reconstructing the earliest recoverable text from that evidence, and modern translations rest on far better manuscript evidence than any earlier century had. A handful of famous passages — the longer ending of Mark, the woman accused of adultery in John, a clause in 1 John — are absent from the earliest manuscripts, and reputable Bibles say so in a footnote.

WHERE DIFFERENCES ACTUALLY COME FROM

Most variation between translations is not ideological. It comes from a genuinely ambiguous word, a construction with no clean English equivalent, a decision about register, or a choice between manuscript readings. Some differences are theologically motivated, and those are worth finding — but assuming that of every difference will make you unable to recognize the real cases when they appear.

> *You do not need the languages to do this work. You need to know where the decisions live, and to look at more than one Bible when a sentence is doing something to somebody.*

THE SPECTRUM

Not a scale from honest to dishonest. A scale from *preserve the structure of the original* to *preserve the effect on the reader* — and every point on it gives something up.

APPROACH	WHAT IT PRIORITIZES	WHAT IT GIVES UP
Interlinear	Word-for-word correspondence, original order preserved under the line.	Readability entirely. A study tool, not a Bible.
Formal "literal"	The original's grammar and ambiguity, kept even where English strains. Leaves the interpretive work to the reader.	Clarity, and sometimes sense. An ambiguity preserved is still an ambiguity you have to solve.
Functional "dynamic"	What the sentence does — meaning transferred into natural English idiom.	The seams. Where the original was ambiguous, the translator has already chosen for you.
Paraphrase	Immediate impact and contemporary voice. Often one author's rendering rather than a committee's.	Any claim to precision. Useful for hearing a passage fresh; unusable for an argument about wording.
Committee vs. solo	Committees produce compromise and consistency; individuals produce voice. Most major translations are committee work, and committees have institutional homes, denominational traditions, funding, and intended audiences — all of which shape the result.	Neither is neutral, and neither is disqualified. Knowing who made it is part of reading it.

WHY FOOTNOTES MATTER MORE THAN THE TRANSLATION YOU CHOSE

A footnote reading *or*, *other manuscripts read*, or *Greek uncertain* is the translator telling you a decision happened here. It is the single most useful habit in this section: when a verse is being used against someone, check whether the page admits an alternative.

CHAPTERS, VERSES, AND HEADINGS ARE NOT SCRIPTURE

Chapter divisions were added in the thirteenth century, verse numbers in the sixteenth, and section headings by modern editors. They make a text findable and quotable — genuinely useful — and they also impose breaks the author did not write. Quoting a single verse is normal and often fine; the question is whether the unit you quoted is doing the work of the unit that surrounds it. Meaning may sit in a phrase, a paragraph, a chapter, a whole book, or the genre.

WHO AUTHORIZED DOMINION'S TRANSLATION, AND WHAT ITS FOOTNOTES ARE ALLOWED TO SAY YOURS

PASSAGE

One spread per passage.
Photocopy before filling.

FOUR RENDERINGS — NAME THE TRANSLATION, THEN COPY THE WORDING EXACTLY

TRANSLATION	HOW IT READS

WHAT THE FOOTNOTES ADMIT — IN ANY OF THE FOUR

WHAT THE DIFFERENCE DOES

THE WORD OR PHRASE THEY HANDLE DIFFERENTLY

THE INTERPRETIVE CHOICE EACH ONE MADE — DESCRIBE IT, DO NOT RANK IT

IS THIS AMBIGUITY, IDIOM, MANUSCRIPT, OR THEOLOGY?

DOES THE DIFFERENCE CHANGE WHAT ANYONE MUST DO?

WHICH RENDERING DOMINION PRINTS, AND WHAT IT GAINS BY IT

WHAT I STILL NEED A REAL SOURCE FOR BEFORE I USE THIS IN A SCENE

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R]

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FOUR TRIGGERS

Comparing English Bibles gets you a long way. These four situations mean stop and find a real source — a lexicon, a commentary, a scholar — before it goes into the novel as a claim.

I · THE ARGUMENT RESTS ON ONE WORD

If a whole doctrine hangs on the range of a single term, the range is the question, and English cannot answer it. This is the situation the household verse is in.

II · THE TRANSLATIONS SPLIT ALONG DENOMINATIONAL LINES

When the pattern of who renders it which way matches the pattern of who teaches what, something other than grammar is operating — and you need to be able to name it precisely rather than gesture at bias.

III · A FOOTNOTE SAYS THE TEXT IS UNCERTAIN

Take the admission seriously. It means the manuscripts disagree or the syntax will not resolve, and building a scene on the resolved version is building on a choice.

IV · YOU ARE ABOUT TO SAY WHAT THE ORIGINAL "REALLY" MEANS

The most dangerous sentence available to a non-specialist, and the one most often deployed with total confidence by people on every side. A character may say it. The companion may not, without a source.

THE CLAIMS ABOUT THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGES I HAVE BEEN REPEATING WITHOUT CHECKING

> *The worked example on the following pages runs all of this on one verse — Ephesians 5, because Dominion's household law is built on it.*

EIGHT QUESTIONS

Run all eight, in order, before deciding what a passage means. Not because it makes you an expert — it does not — but because most confident misuse of scripture happens by skipping one of them, and skipping is easy to catch in yourself if you have a list.

1 · WHAT KIND OF TEXT IS THIS?

Genre first, always. It decides what the passage is capable of establishing before any other question is worth asking.

2 · WHO IS SPEAKING?

The narrator, a character, God as quoted, a rival, a friend who turns out to be wrong. Job's comforters are in the Bible and they are mistaken, and the book says so.

3 · TO WHOM?

A congregation with a specific problem, a king, a foreign nation, an individual. Applying an oracle addressed to Babylon to yourself is a category error with a long history.

4 · WHAT COMES BEFORE AND AFTER?

Read the paragraph, then the chapter. Most weaponized verses are load-bearing only when the sentence on either side has been removed.

5 · WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT?

Empire, occupation, exile, monarchy, household economy, legal status of women and slaves. The setting is not background; it is frequently the subject.

6 · WHAT DO THE WORDS DO?

Command, describe, lament, promise, threaten, concede, argue. Compare two translations and see whether they agree about which.

7 · WHO GAINS FROM THIS READING?

Ask it of every reading, including the one you prefer. A reading that benefits you is not thereby wrong — it is thereby worth checking twice.

8 · WHAT DOES THIS READING COST?

And who pays it. This is the question Dominion has never once asked out loud, and the one Eden will eventually be unable to stop asking.

> **WHAT THE METHOD ACTUALLY BUYS YOU**
>
> Not authority over people who quote this book for a living. Many of them run these questions better than you will. What it buys is the ability to tell the difference between a reading that has done the work and one that has skipped a step — including your own — and to name which step.

PASSAGE

TRANSLATION USED

1 · GENRE

2 · SPEAKER

3 · AUDIENCE

4 · WHAT SURROUNDS IT

5 · HISTORICAL CONTEXT — WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT

6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO — AND WHETHER TWO TRANSLATIONS AGREE

THE INTERPRETIVE DISPUTE — WHO READS IT WHICH WAY, AND ON WHAT EVIDENCE

WHO GAINS, WHO PAYS

7 · WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING

8 · WHAT EACH READING COSTS, AND WHO PAYS IT

DOMINION'S OFFICIAL READING — AND HOW IT IS TAUGHT

WHERE I CURRENTLY LAND, IN MY OWN WORDS

RESEARCH STILL NEEDED

WHICH CHARACTER HOLDS WHICH READING

TKC APPLICATION — THE SCENE, THE CHAPTER, OR THE DOCTRINE THIS FEEDS

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EIGHT FAULT LINES

The eight places where reading this book divides people, and where Dominion has a doctrine. Research will not produce universal agreement on any of them — but it reliably rules out weak claims and clarifies what the argument is actually about, which is most of the work.

FAULT LINE	WHAT IS ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE	WHERE TKC USES IT
Headship	The range of one Greek noun, the scope of the mutual-submission verse, and what transfers out of a Roman household code.	The Binding. Every household in the Empire.
Women speaking	Restriction passages in the Pauline corpus set against the undisputed letters that name women as coworkers, a deacon, and an apostle. Authorship and dating are load-bearing — do not say "the same author" across that boundary.	The Vowed. Who may teach, and who may only recite.
Slavery	Texts that regulate rather than abolish, and the interpretive principle by which a tradition later called it wrong. The principle is the argument; the verses are not in doubt.	Designation. Labor tracks. Which people are assignable.
Divine violence	Conquest narratives and judgment oracles: historical reporting, theological rhetoric, later reflection, or ancient war convention — and how any of it relates to a God described elsewhere as merciful.	The Fall. Every purge justified as cleansing.
Obedience to rulers	Romans 13 against the prophets, Revelation, and the movement's own martyrdoms. Whether the instruction is general principle or situational counsel to a vulnerable congregation in the imperial capital.	The Empire's single most quoted text. Its whole legitimacy.
Wealth	Whether the warnings are about attachment, about structural injustice, or about literal divestment — and whether prosperity language in the wisdom books qualifies them or is qualified by them.	Crownward theology. Blessing as evidence of favor.
Purity & the body	Which regulations are which, and by whose framework. The ritual/moral distinction is a later interpretive category applied to the material, not a label printed inside it — and the sorting is where the whole argument happens.	Designation exams. The Salt Ceremony. Bodies as records.
The end of things	Apocalyptic read as address to its own moment, as future program, as recurring pattern, or as liturgy. Permanently and visibly contested; a companion that resolves it has stopped being useful.	Whose reading is orthodoxy, and whose is sedition.

NOT ALL CONTESTED ALIKE

The most important distinction in this section. Treating all four as equally open is how a companion becomes useless — and how a well-read person ends up unable to say that something is simply false.

I · SERIOUS SCHOLARLY DISPUTE

Specialists with the languages, the manuscripts, and the historical training disagree, and each side can state the other's evidence. The range of *kephalē*. The authorship of Ephesians. Represent both; do not pick a winner in the companion's own voice.

II · DENOMINATIONAL OR TRADITIONAL DISAGREEMENT

Communities differ because of confessional commitments, governance, and inherited practice — not primarily because of contested evidence. Who may be ordained. Whether Revelation is read aloud. Name the tradition rather than treating its position as the neutral one.

III · OPEN THEOLOGICAL INTERPRETATION

Questions the text raises and does not close, where evidence runs out and judgment begins. What the conquest narratives say about God. Whether Job is answered. These stay open honestly, and they are where a novel does its best work.

IV · UNSUPPORTED CLAIM OR MISINFORMATION

Assertions that fail on the evidence: invented etymologies, a word supposedly mistranslated in every Bible, a council that decided something it did not discuss, a manuscript claim no one can produce. These are not contested. They are wrong, and the companion is allowed to say so — while noting that a character may believe one sincerely and build a life on it.

THE SORTING QUESTION

Before writing any dispute into a scene: which of the four is it? Category I earns two credible characters. Category IV earns one character who is wrong and one who knows it — and that is a different scene entirely.

THE CATEGORY IV CLAIM DOMINION TEACHES AS SETTLED FACT

FAULT LINE

KIND — I / II / III / IV

THE RELEVANT PASSAGES — WITH REFERENCES

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

THE MAJOR READINGS — WHO HOLDS EACH, AND WHAT EVIDENCE IT USES

THE READING	WHO HOLDS IT	ON WHAT EVIDENCE

THE EMPIRE AND THE PEOPLE

WHAT DOMINION OFFICIALLY TEACHES

WHAT IT SUPPRESSES, AND HOW

WHO IN THE NOVEL STANDS WHERE

CHARACTER	AGREES · DOUBTS · RESISTS · REINTERPRETS	WHAT IT COSTS HER, AND WHEN SHE LEARNED IT

WHAT REMAINS UNRESOLVED — AND SHOULD

WHAT I STILL NEED A SOURCE FOR

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EPHESIANS 5

The worked example, because Dominion's household law is built on this passage and because everything difficult about reading scripture is present in it at once — a disputed author, a supplied verb, a contested word, a Roman legal background, and a verse break in the wrong place.

WHERE THE SENTENCE ACTUALLY STARTS INFORMATION

Verse 21 instructs the whole congregation to submit to one another. Verse 22 addresses wives. Several of the earliest and most heavily weighted Greek witnesses have no verb in verse 22 at all — the instruction to wives depends on the participle governing verse 21, which makes the two verses one grammatical movement rather than two topics. Other manuscripts supply a verb, and most English Bibles supply one too, along with a section heading printed between the verses. That heading is modern editorial apparatus, not scripture. MSS: P46 · SINAITICUS · VATICANUS

WHAT THE PARTICIPLE DOES, AND WHAT IT DOES NOT SETTLE CONTESTED

The grammatical link is not in dispute; what it implies is. One reading holds that mutual submission in 21 governs everything after it, so the household instructions are applications of a shared obligation. Another holds that 21 introduces submission generally and 22 onward specifies its ordered forms, so mutuality and hierarchy are compatible. Both are argued by serious scholars, and the grammar alone does not decide between them — anyone who tells you the Greek settles it is overselling, in either direction.

THE AUTHORSHIP QUESTION, WHICH MATTERS HERE

Ephesians is one of the disputed letters. Whether Paul wrote it is genuinely divided among scholars, which affects any argument that runs "the same author who names women as coworkers also said this." Use *the Pauline corpus* when arguing across that line.

THE STRUCTURAL LESSON — THIS IS THE PART TO KEEP

Quote verse 22 alone and you have a rule for wives. Quote 21 through 33 and you have a passage that gives the husband roughly three times as many verses of instruction. The mechanism is not mistranslation — it is fragment selection, plus a heading, plus teaching the doctrine before anyone reads the paragraph. Any institution with a lectionary and a catechism can do it without altering a single word, and this is a documented pattern in the history of Christian household teaching rather than a hypothetical. HIST: HOUSEHOLD-CODE RECEPTION

HEAD

The Greek word is *kephalē*. Its semantic range in this period is one of the most contested questions in New Testament lexicography, and the dispute is genuine — not a case where one side has the evidence and the other has a preference.

PROPOSED SENSE	THE CASE FOR IT, AND THE STRAIN AGAINST IT
Authority over	Well attested in Greek usage of the era for rulers and governing bodies, and the natural reading if the passage is arranging a hierarchy. Strain: the immediate context defines the husband's headship by self-giving and by nourishing, not by command, and no order is issued to husbands anywhere in the passage.
Source or origin	Attested in some contexts — a river's head, a source of supply — and fits the body imagery the passage builds, where the head supplies and the body grows. Strain: how common this sense was in ordinary first-century usage is exactly what specialists disagree about.
Preeminence	A middle position: foremost, most prominent, first in honor, without a command relationship attached. Strain: honor and authority are hard to keep separate in a society organized around both.
Metaphor, unresolved	That the writer is working an extended body metaphor and did not intend a precise institutional definition — which would explain why two millennia of readers have extracted incompatible institutions from it.

THE WORD RENDERED "SUBMIT"

It is voluntary in form rather than commanded from outside — the construction implies something the subject does, not something done to her. That is a real feature of the grammar and it is not a solution: a voluntary act performed inside a legal system where the alternative is destitution is voluntary in a limited sense. Dominion understands this perfectly. The Empire never forces; it makes the alternative unlivable.

WHAT NOT TO DO WITH THIS PAGE

Do not use it to announce that the Greek has been solved and the hierarchy dissolved. The companion's job is to make you able to say which sense a reading assumes and what that assumption costs — a much sharper instrument than a verdict you cannot defend.

WHICH SENSE DOMINION'S DOCTRINE ASSUMES — AND WHETHER ITS PRELATES KNOW THERE IS A CHOICE

THE HOUSEHOLD CODE

Wives, children, slaves, addressed in that order, is not an invention of this letter. It is a recognizable Greco-Roman form — moral instruction on managing a household, which was a political unit as much as a domestic one, because the ordered household was understood to be the foundation of the ordered state.

WHAT THE FORM ASSUMES

A male head with legal authority over wife, children, and enslaved people; the household as an economic enterprise; and the state's interest in its order. A first-century reader would recognize the shape immediately and would notice the departures.

WHERE THIS VERSION DEPARTS FROM THE FORM CONTESTED

It addresses the subordinate parties directly as moral agents rather than as property to be managed. It gives the husband the longer and more demanding instruction. It grounds the whole arrangement in self-giving rather than in the head's prerogative. Whether these departures amount to subversion of the code, a Christianized version of it, or an accommodation that made the movement socially survivable is a live scholarly argument — and all three readings are held by people who have done the work.

THE INSTRUCTIONS TO HUSBANDS — READ THEM, THEY ARE THE MAJORITY OF THE PASSAGE

Love as Christ loved and gave himself up. Nourish and cherish as one's own body. The passage issues the husband no command to rule, no instruction to enforce, and no license to correct. A doctrine of headship that produces enforcement is therefore drawing on the noun in verse 23 rather than on anything the passage tells husbands to do \u2014 and what it tells them to do occupies most of its length. EPH 5.25\u201333

THE PART NOBODY QUOTES AT WEDDINGS

The same code continues into instructions to enslaved people and their masters. Any institution that treats the wives section as timeless and the slavery section as historically conditioned is making an interpretive decision it usually declines to defend — and noticing that is the most useful single move available to a character inside such an institution.

HOW DOMINION HANDLES THE SLAVERY SECTION OF THE SAME PASSAGE

FOUR POSITIONS

Held by real people with real arguments. Learn to state each one in its own terms before deciding anything — a character who can only caricature the opposing reading is not yet a character who has thought about it.

POSITION	WHAT IT HOLDS, AND ON WHAT EVIDENCE	ITS HARDEST PROBLEM
Ordered roles	Distinct and permanent roles: the husband leads, the wife submits, both equal in worth. Rests on the plain sense of headship in the era's usage and on the ordering of the code itself.	Nothing in the passage authorizes enforcement, and verse 21 addresses everyone.
Mutual submission	Verse 21 governs the whole section; the household instructions apply a shared obligation. Rests on the grammar of the participle and on the content of the husband's instructions.	The instructions are still asymmetrical in form, and the code's order is still the code's order.
Historically situated	A first-century congregation being taught to live inside an existing legal structure without being destroyed by it. Rests on the household-code parallels and on the letter's occasional character.	Requires a principle for deciding what transfers to other centuries, and stating that principle is hard.
Accommodation	A movement softening its radical edge to survive scrutiny — the household code as respectability. Rests on the trajectory from the undisputed letters toward the Pastorals.	Depends on the authorship and dating questions, which are not settled.

> *Assign one to each character who has an opinion. Then assign one to a character who has never been told there is more than one, which is most of the Empire.*

THE METHOD, WORKED

The eight questions from the previous section, answered on this passage, so you can see the shape of a completed run before doing your own.

1 · KIND OF TEXT	Letter, containing a household code — occasional correspondence, not legislation, and a recognizable moral-instruction form embedded in it.
2 · SPEAKER	The letter's author, writing in Paul's name; authorship genuinely disputed. Not a narrator reporting, and not God quoted directly.
3 · AUDIENCE	A congregation — or several — in the Roman province of Asia. Wives, husbands, children, and enslaved people are all addressed as present and listening.
4 · BEFORE & AFTER	Before: mutual submission, addressed to all. After: husbands, then children and parents, then enslaved people and masters. The wives instruction is the shortest unit in the sequence.
5 · THE WORLD	Roman legal households with a male head, an economy that included slavery, a state invested in domestic order, and a small movement under intermittent suspicion.
6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO	Instruct, using a participle dependent on the preceding sentence. One contested noun. The husband's portion is longer and makes the heavier demand.
7 · WHO GAINS	From the fragment: whoever holds household authority, and any state that needs households orderly. From the whole passage: considerably less clear, which is why the fragment is what gets printed.
8 · WHAT IT COSTS	Under the fragment reading: a woman's standing depends on a man's character, with no recourse written into the text. Ask who in Aurelia pays that, and what she is told when she says so.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

This passage is the seed of the Binding, the Covenant, and every household in the Empire. Write what Dominion did with it — and what you were taught about it long before you read the paragraph.

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT THIS PASSAGE MEANT, AND WHO TAUGHT ME

DOMINION'S OFFICIAL DOCTRINE OF HEADSHIP — IN THE EMPIRE'S OWN WORDS

WHICH VERSES THE TEMPLE PRINTS, AND WHICH IT LEAVES FOR CLERGY

THE MOMENT EDEN READS THE WHOLE PARAGRAPH FOR THE FIRST TIME

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PART ONE · X

THE SIXTY-SIX BOOKS

One entry per book, in canonical order, and every entry answers the same six questions so you can compare across the whole library instead of reading each book in isolation. None of these is a substitute for reading the book itself. They are orientation — enough to know what you are walking into, what the book argues about, and which of its pressures your novel can use.

Two of the six questions are yours rather than the Bible's. *What it gives TKC* is where the raw material gets named, and *what Dominion would do with it* is where you decide how the Empire has already processed the book before any character opens it. Answer those in pencil; they will change as the manuscript changes.

The narrative-heavy books get a full page each, because story is where characters come from and you will return to them constantly. The shorter prophetic and epistolary books share pages, two to a spread, because what you need from them is a fast, reliable sense of the argument rather than a scene inventory. The layout is telling you how much material is in there.

THE SIX QUESTIONS

Where we are — the political and historical position.

What happens — the shape of the thing, briefly.

Who matters — the names worth knowing.

What it wrestles with — the internal argument.

What it gives TKC — usable material.

What Dominion would do with it — the Empire's use.

READING ORDER, IF YOU WANT ONE

Canonical order is not chronological and is a poor first path. If you would rather read for competence than completeness, take this route: Genesis, Exodus, Judges, 1–2 Samuel, then Mark, then Luke, then Amos and Isaiah, then Esther and Ruth, then Romans, then Revelation. That gives you origins, law, monarchy, prophetic anger, exile, a life, a movement, and an apocalypse — the whole grammar of what Dominion is built on, in about a tenth of the pages.

Then come back and do it properly.

"Sixty-six books, and no two of them were written for you."

GENESIS

Bereshit · fifty chapters · Book i of lxvi

OT | ORIGINS

START HERE

Ch. 1–3 · 16 · 21 · 22 · 29–30 · 38

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

Before nation, before law, before temple. There is no state in this book and no priesthood, only households — which means everything the Empire later cites as eternal precedent begins its life as a family argument about land, inheritance, and whose child counts.

WHAT HAPPENS

Two creation accounts that do not match, an expulsion, a flood, a scattered tower — then thirty-eight chapters narrowing to one family: a promise, a wife who laughs at it, an enslaved surrogate driven into a desert, twin sons who cheat each other, two sisters married to the same man, and a favoured son sold by his brothers who ends up administering an empire's grain.

WHO MATTERS

Eve · Noah · Sarah · **Hagar** · Abraham · Isaac · Rebekah · Jacob · **Leah** · Rachel · Dinah · **Tamar** · Joseph

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Blessing as a scarce resource that cannot be shared, only won or stolen. Naming as an act of authority. Whether obedience is trust or terror — the book never resolves it, and the near-sacrifice of Isaac is left standing without comment.

"You are the God who sees me." HAGAR · GEN 16.13

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The garden as a supervised enclosure with one prohibition. Naming as ownership. The sister-rivalry template beneath the candidate system. And Hagar: the woman used for someone else's promise, who is the first person in the book to name God.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Read a curse as a constitution. Order of creation becomes order of rank, the expulsion becomes the founding case for permanent supervision, and Hagar becomes a cautionary tale about women who run instead of a woman God followed into the desert.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Hagar, p. 101; Leah, p. 104; Symbols — Garden, p. 141.

EXODUS

Shemot · forty chapters · Book ii of lxvi

OT | EMPIRE

START HERE

Ch. 1–3 · 5 · 12 · 15 · 20 · 32

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

Inside an empire, as its labour force. The family from Genesis has become a population, and the state that once fed them now fears their numbers enough to legislate against their children. This is the book where God is first identified as the one who takes sides in a labour dispute.

WHAT HAPPENS

Midwives disobey a royal infanticide order and are commended for it. A child is hidden, raised in the palace, kills a slavedriver, flees, and is recruited from a burning bush. He returns and negotiates with the state through escalating catastrophe until the workforce walks out. Then a sea, a mountain, a law, and a gold statue.

WHO MATTERS

Shiphrah & Puah · Jochebed · **Miriam** · Pharaoh's daughter · Moses · Zipporah · Aaron · Pharaoh

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether freedom is the point or only the precondition — the people are barely out before they are given a legal code and a building project. Also the terrible arithmetic of liberation: this book's God kills other people's children to free these ones, and the text does not soften it.

"I have heard their cry on account of their taskmasters." EX 3.7

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The template for holy disobedience: two midwives who lie to a king and are recorded by name while the king is not. A liberation story that any oppressed population inside Dominion can read and apply without a single word of commentary.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Move the emphasis from the escape to the mountain. Teach Exodus as the book where God gives commandments and punishes the golden calf, not the book where God overthrows a government. Freedom becomes prologue; obedience becomes the moral.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Empires of the Bible, p. 192; Passages Dominion Would Suppress, p. 220.

LEVITICUS

Vayikra · twenty-seven chapters · Book iii of lxvi

OT | RITUAL

START HERE

Ch. 10 · 12 · 16 · 19 · 25

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

Still at the mountain, and nothing happens. This is the book people give up on, and it is also the most important book in the collection for understanding how a religion actually governs, because it is almost entirely administration: who may touch what, who may enter where, what a body renders unclean, and what it costs to be restored.

WHAT HAPPENS

Sacrificial procedure, two priests killed for improvising a ritual, dietary law, childbirth and menstruation as states requiring separation, a day of atonement, prohibition lists, festival calendars — and then, startlingly, jubilee: every fifty years, debts cancelled and land returned to the families who lost it.

WHO MATTERS

Aaron · Nadab & Abihu · the anonymous priesthood · the scapegoat

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Holiness as separation rather than morality, and the enormous machinery required to maintain it. Underneath the procedure is a question your Empire has to answer: is a body a temple to be guarded, or a liability to be managed?

"Proclaim liberty throughout the land, to all its inhabitants." LEV 25.10

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The entire vocabulary of ritual purity that a surveillance theocracy runs on: clean and unclean, permitted and withheld, the body as a jurisdiction. Every ceremony, inspection and enclosure in Dominion can be sourced here.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Enforce the purity codes with total literalism and treat jubilee as symbolic. Debt release and land restoration are the most economically dangerous laws in scripture; an empire built on inheritance quietly reclassifies them as poetry.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Ritual, Law & Practice, p. 175; Sex, Desire & the Body, p. 300.

NUMBERS

Bemidbar · thirty-six chapters · Book iv of lxvi

OT | AUTHORITY

START HERE

Ch. 12 · 13–14 · 16 · 22 · 27

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

In the desert, and it is going badly. The Hebrew name means *in the wilderness*; the English name comes from the two censuses that bracket the book. Both titles are honest: this is a book about counting a population and about that population falling apart while it waits.

WHAT HAPPENS

A census, then complaint after complaint: food, leadership, the wisdom of the whole project. Scouts return terrified and the people are sentenced to forty years of wandering. Miriam challenges Moses and is struck with disease; a rebellion is swallowed by the ground. Five daughters petition successfully to inherit their father's land.

WHO MATTERS

Miriam · Korah · Caleb · Joshua · Balaam · **the daughters of Zelophehad**

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Legitimate authority and the cost of questioning it. Rebellions here are punished spectacularly — and yet in the same book five women bring a legal challenge to inheritance law and win, with God ruling in their favour. The text cannot decide whether dissent is faithlessness or petition, and neither can any empire.

"The daughters of Zelophehad are right." NUM 27.7

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

A census as an instrument of control, and the one precedent in the Torah for women successfully changing the law by asking. Also the psychology of a generation that will not live to see the promise — useful for anyone in Dominion serving a future they have been told is not theirs.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Preach Korah every year and Zelophehad never. Rebellion swallowed by the earth is an excellent lesson for a provincial congregation; a successful female petition to amend inheritance law is not printed in the schoolbook.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Family, Lineage & Inheritance, p. 293; Miriam, p. 102.

DEUTERONOMY

Devarim · thirty-four chapters · Book v of lxvi

OT | DOMINION

START HERE

Ch. 6 · 15 · 17 · 22 · 28 · 30 · 34

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

On the border, listening to a farewell address. The whole book is one long speech delivered to a generation that did not witness the escape, which makes it the first act of national memory management in the collection: this is what happened to us, this is what it means, this is what you owe.

WHAT HAPPENS

The law is restated for a settled agricultural people, then blessings and curses laid out as a conditional contract: obey and the land yields, disobey and it is taken. Laws limiting kings, protecting immigrants and releasing debts sit beside laws of terrifying severity. It ends with a leader dying in sight of a country he may not enter.

WHO MATTERS

Moses · Joshua · the unnamed generation being addressed

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

The retribution formula: righteousness produces prosperity, suffering implies sin. It is the most quotable theology in scripture and the most politically useful, because it makes wealth a certificate of virtue and poverty a confession. Job and several prophets exist largely to contradict it.

"He shall not multiply horses, nor wives, nor silver and gold for himself."

ON KINGS · DEUT 17

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Dominion's founding logic, ready-made: a covenant contract in which national obedience produces national survival. It also gives you the buried law limiting what a king may accumulate — a passage that indicts your Emperor in a single sentence.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Make this the spine of state theology. Blessing for compliance, catastrophe for dissent, and every hardship in the provinces explained as somebody's hidden disobedience. The debt-release and immigrant-protection laws stay in the canon and out of the lectionary.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Building Dominion's Religion, p. 228; Obedience, p. 203; Job, p. 048.

JOSHUA

Yehoshua · twenty-four chapters · Book vi of lxvi

OT · CONQUEST

START HERE

Ch. 2 · 6 · 7 · 24

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

Crossing into the land, with military force. This is where a promise becomes a campaign, and it is the hardest book in the collection to read honestly, because what is described is the taking of inhabited cities and it is described as obedience.

WHAT HAPPENS

Two spies are hidden by a prostitute in Jericho who negotiates her household's survival in exchange. A wall falls. One man keeps plunder and his whole family is executed for it. Campaign follows campaign, the land is divided by lot, and the book closes with a public assembly where the people must formally choose whose god they serve.

WHO MATTERS

Joshua · **Rahab** · Achan · Caleb · the Gibeonites, who survive by lying well

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether divine promise can license atrocity, and whether belonging is blood or allegiance. Its own answer is inconsistent: the foreigners who talk their way in are kept, and one ends up in the royal genealogy.

"Choose this day whom you will serve." JOSH 24.15

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Rahab, entirely. A woman with no standing who reads the political situation faster than her whole city and trades information for her family's survival.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Quote it in every expansion, and use Achan as the case for collective punishment: one household endangers the nation, therefore surveillance is mercy.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Rahab, p. 103; Divine Violence, p. 010.

JUDGES

Shoftim · twenty-one chapters · Book vii of lxvi

OT | DOMINION

START HERE

Ch. 4–5 · 11 · 16 · 19–21

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

In the land, with no central government, and it is a catastrophe. The book runs a cycle — the people go wrong, a foreign power oppresses them, a temporary leader rises, peace, then again — and each turn is uglier than the last.

WHAT HAPPENS

A woman judges the nation and wins a war; another drives a tent peg through a general's skull. A man sacrifices his daughter to keep a vow. A strongman is undone by his appetites. It ends in gang rape, civil war, and the mass abduction of women to repopulate the losing tribe.

WHO MATTERS

Deborah · **Jael** · Gideon · Jephthah and his daughter · Samson · **Delilah** · the unnamed woman of ch. 19

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether the absence of a king is freedom or collapse. It is arguing for monarchy, and it argues by showing you what happens to women when no one is in charge — which is a very specific and very political way to make a case for order.

"There was no king; everyone did what was right in his own eyes." JUDG 21.25

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Deborah — a woman with unquestioned public authority whom no empire can quite explain away. And the chapter 19 woman, the strongest argument in scripture that the state's protection was never the point.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Use the closing verse as a founding slogan: chaos is what happens without a divinely ordered ruler. Deborah becomes an emergency exception; Delilah becomes the lesson about female influence.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Deborah, p. 105; Power & Kingship, p. 307.

RUTH

four chapters · Book viii of lxvi

OT · CHARACTER

START HERE

All four chapters. It is short.

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

In the same period as Judges, deliberately, and reading like its rebuttal. Four quiet chapters about two widows and a harvest, placed immediately after the most violent book in the collection, arguing that survival is arranged by ordinary loyalty rather than by warlords.

WHAT HAPPENS

A famine drives a family abroad. The men all die. A foreign daughter-in-law refuses to leave her mother-in-law and returns with her to a town with no income and no standing. She gleans in a field, is noticed by its owner, and then — on her mother-in-law's coaching — goes to him at night on a threshing floor and asks him directly to marry her. He does. Their great-grandson is David.

WHO MATTERS

Ruth · **Naomi** · Boaz · the unnamed nearer kinsman who declines

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Who counts as one of us. Ruth is a Moabite, from precisely the nation another book bars from the assembly, and she is written into the royal line on purpose. The book is a quiet act of political dissent about immigration and belonging.

"Where you go I will go. Your people shall be my people." RUTH 1.16

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The most famous line of devotion in scripture is spoken by a woman to another woman, not to a husband or a god. That single fact will do more for your relationship writing than any romance in the collection.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Read it at every wedding, with the vow reassigned to a husband and the threshing floor scene softened into modesty. A foreign woman who assimilates completely is the Empire's favourite kind of immigrant.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC *write here*

✣ *See also:* Ruth, p. 106; Relationship Theology, p. 287.

1 & 2 SAMUEL

fifty-five chapters · Books ix–x of lxvi

OT | DOMINION

START HERE

1 Sam 1–2 · 8 · 16–18 · 25
2 Sam 6 · 11–12 · 13

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

At the invention of the monarchy, and ambivalent about it from the first page. The people demand a king; the prophet warns them exactly what a king will take — their sons, their daughters, a tenth of everything — and anoints one anyway.

WHAT HAPPENS

A barren woman hands her son to the temple; her song becomes the template for every reversal-of-power hymn after it. Saul is chosen, unravels, dies. David rises, then takes a woman and has her husband killed to cover it. A prophet walks into the palace and says so. The rest is a family destroying itself.

WHO MATTERS

Hannah · Samuel · Saul · **Michal** · David · Jonathan · **Abigail** · **Bathsheba** · Nathan · **Tamar** · Absalom

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether a chosen king can be held to account. The astonishing thing is that the book keeps David's crimes in — the state's founding hero is a rapist and a murderer, and the text says so plainly. Every empire descended from this literature has to decide whether to keep that page.

"You are the man." NATHAN TO THE KING · 2 SAM 12.7

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The anatomy of your court: anointing, succession, a prophet who can indict a king and survive, and Tamar — a princess assaulted inside the palace whose case is buried to protect the dynasty.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Keep the anointing, keep the giant-killing, and reframe Bathsheba as a temptation rather than a crime. Nathan's confrontation becomes a story about private repentance instead of public accountability.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Bathsheba, p. 108; Tamar of the palace, p. 109; Prophecy & Who Gets Believed, p. 315.

1 & 2 KINGS

forty-seven chapters · Books xi–xii of lxvi

OT | EMPIRE

START HERE

1 Kgs 3 · 12 · 18 · 21
2 Kgs 11 · 22 · 25

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

At the height of the state, then all the way down — the book of the temple's construction and its destruction, written from captivity by people explaining how they lost everything.

WHAT HAPPENS

Solomon builds the temple with forced labour, and at his death the kingdom splits over that grievance. Then a catalogue of kings, each rated in a sentence, punctuated by prophets who confront them — Elijah against a royal couple who seize a vineyard by judicial murder. A forgotten scroll is found and triggers a purge. Then Assyria, Babylon, and the temple burned.

WHO MATTERS

Solomon · **the queen of Sheba** · Elijah · **Jezebel** · Naboth · Elisha · **Athaliah** · **Huldah** · Josiah · Nebuchadnezzar

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Why the state fell, answered theologically rather than militarily: the kings were unfaithful. A convenient explanation, and a dangerous one — every disaster becomes somebody's insufficient devotion.

"Have you killed and also taken possession?" ELIJAH TO AHAB · 1 KGS 21.19

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Naboth's vineyard: how a state takes what it wants and keeps the paperwork clean. Plus Huldah, a woman authenticating scripture for a king, and Athaliah, a queen whose reign was written up as usurpation.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Preach the temple and the reforming king; skip the forced labour that built it. Jezebel becomes the standing image of a woman with political power, which is precisely why the name survives as an insult and Naboth's does not.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Jezebel, p. 110; Huldah, p. 111; Empires of the Bible, p. 192.

THREE BOOKS TOGETHER · xiii–xvi

CHRONICLES · EZRA · NEHEMIAH

These three share a page because they do one job: they are the authorised version. Written after the exile by the returning establishment, they retell the national story with the failures managed. This is what state-sponsored scripture looks like from the inside.

1 & 2 CHRON

sixty-five chapters

The same monarchy retold with the scandals removed. Bathsheba is gone. Absalom's rebellion is gone. Nine chapters of genealogy open the book, because lineage is the argument — this priesthood, this line, this temple, legitimately. Where Kings explains a catastrophe, Chronicles builds a credential.

For TKC: this is Dominion's own historiography. Two accounts of the same reign, one of which has been cleaned — and a character who finds both.

EZRA

ten chapters

A permitted return under imperial licence, a rebuilt temple, then a purity crisis: the community is ordered to send away its foreign wives and their children. One of the coldest passages in scripture, four books from Ruth, which says the opposite.

For TKC: ethnic purity legislated as obedience, with the paperwork of restoration.

NEHEMIAH

thirteen chapters

A civil servant of a foreign empire gets leave to rebuild his city's walls, and it reads like a project memoir: opposition, logistics, night inspections, armed builders. Buried in the middle is a debt crisis where the poor are mortgaging their children, and he forces the wealthy to cancel it.

For TKC: walls, gates, registers, and a reformer aimed at his own class.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH ALL THREE

Make Chronicles the standard history and let Kings go quietly out of print. Cite Ezra whenever purity needs enforcing and Nehemiah whenever a wall needs building — and never, ever read the debt-cancellation chapter aloud.

CONTESTED

Whether Ezra's mass divorce was survival for a tiny community or ethnic cleansing with a liturgy is argued in good faith both ways. Your Empire has definitely picked one.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC *write here*

ESTHER

ten chapters · Book xvii of lxvi

OT · CHARACTER

START HERE

Ch. 1 · 2 · 4 · 7. Read ch. 1 twice.

ECHOES

Eden · Celeste · Lyris

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

Inside the palace of a foreign empire, entirely. No temple, no prophet, no law, and God is never mentioned — which is why it nearly missed the canon, and why it is the most useful book here for writing a woman surviving a court.

WHAT HAPPENS

A queen refuses to be displayed and is removed. A nationwide search gathers young women into the palace for a year of preparation. An orphan, told by her cousin to conceal her ethnicity, becomes queen. A minister engineers a genocide. She risks an unsummoned approach, works the king through two banquets, and turns the decree back on its author.

WHO MATTERS

Vashti · **Esther** · Mordecai · Haman · the king, who is manipulated by everyone

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

How to act when you have no power, no God on the page, and no guarantee. The book's ethics are entirely improvised — concealment, timing, flattery, hospitality as strategy — and it never once tells you whether that is admirable.

"If I perish, I perish." EST 4.16

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Your candidate system, nearly wholesale: a state selection, a year of preparation, a girl told to hide what she is. And Vashti — who says no in chapter one and is erased, making the whole plot possible.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Canonise her as the patient wife: proof that a woman's power is beauty, obedience and correct timing. Vashti is preached as the warning; the year of preparation is presented as honour rather than processing.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Esther, p. 114; Vashti, p. 113; Eden's dossier, p. 248.

JOB

forty-two chapters · Book xviii of lxvi

OT · CONTESTED

START HERE

Ch. 1–3 · 19 · 38–42

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

Nowhere in particular, deliberately. No Israel, no temple, no law — a placeless story built to test one idea to destruction: that suffering is earned. This book exists to argue with Deuteronomy.

WHAT HAPPENS

A blameless man loses everything as the subject of a wager he never learns about. Three friends spend twenty-five chapters explaining, with impeccable orthodoxy, that he must have deserved it. He refuses to agree and accuses God to God's face. God answers with a whirlwind of questions, then tells the friends they were wrong and Job was right.

WHO MATTERS

Job · his wife, who has one devastating line · Eliphaz, Bildad, Zophar · the whirlwind

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether God is fair, and whether piety that refuses to lie about pain counts as faith. The verdict is startling: the man who accuses God is commended; the men who defended God with correct doctrine are rebuked.

"My lips will not speak falsehood." JOB 27.4

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Authority for the character who refuses the official explanation of her own suffering — the canon's own proof that the pious answer can be the wrong one.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Teach the first two chapters and the last. Patient endurance and restored fortunes preach well; a man winning an argument with God does not.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Deuteronomy, p. 016; Obedience, p. 203.

PSALMS

one hundred and fifty · Book xix of lxvi

OT · LITURGY

START HERE

Ps 13 · 22 · 23 · 51 · 88 · 137 · 139 · 146

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

In public worship, over centuries. This is a hymnbook and a liturgy, assembled from many hands, and it is the single most quoted book in the collection — which makes it the most fought-over.

WHAT HAPPENS

Every emotion a religion will admit to, in a fixed set of forms: praise, thanksgiving, royal coronation songs, and — nearly a third of the book — lament, in which the speaker accuses God of absence and demands an answer. Some psalms curse enemies in language no state would print. One asks how long God intends to hide.

WHO MATTERS

No characters. The speaker is a voice — sometimes a king, sometimes a fugitive, sometimes a congregation, often a person alone at night.

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether God can be addressed honestly. The remarkable thing is that complaint is a liturgical form here — the tradition built official language for accusing its own God, and then most institutions stopped using it.

"How long will you hide your face from me?" PS 13.1

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Your entire liturgy bank — and the lament form, which gives a character a sanctioned way to say the unsayable in public. A forbidden psalm is a very small, very dangerous object.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Keep the praise and the royal psalms; retire the laments to a clergy-only volume. An empire cannot hold mass worship on a text that teaches the congregation to ask where God has gone.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Prayer & Language Bank, p. 250.

PROVERBS · ECCLESIASTES · SONG OF SONGS

Books xx–xxii · read against each other: life is orderly, life is vapour, never mind — look at this body.

PROVERBS

thirty-one chapters

Instruction for young men entering public life: work hard, hold your tongue, avoid the wrong woman. Wisdom herself is a woman who shouts in the streets and was present at creation — the boldest female figure in the Old Testament, rarely preached as one. It closes with a formidable woman running an estate, routinely quoted at wives as a domestic standard.

For TKC: the exact register of Dominion's advice literature — and the fact that its own ideal woman is an entrepreneur, not an ornament.

ECCLESIASTES

twelve chapters

A man with unlimited resources tests every route to meaning and reports that all of it is vapour, that the wise and the fool meet the same end, and that nobody will remember you. Its counsel is small: eat your bread, love someone, the day is short.

For TKC: the voice of someone inside the palace who has stopped believing the palace means anything. Devastating in a courtier's mouth.

SONG OF SONGS

eight chapters

Erotic poetry, unembarrassed, with no mention of God, marriage, children or duty. The woman speaks most of the lines, initiates, and is never rebuked for it. Centuries of allegorical reading exist mainly to make this respectable.

For TKC: desire with scriptural standing, and a woman's voice as the loudest in the book. The Empire's most awkward inheritance.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH ALL THREE

Teach Proverbs as law, allegorise the Song until the bodies disappear, and leave Ecclesiastes out of the provincial edition.

CONTESTED

Whether the Song is human love poetry or an allegory of divine love has been argued for two thousand years. Which one Dominion teaches decides what your characters are permitted to want.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

BEFORE YOU READ ANY OF THEM

HOW PROPHECY WORKS

A prophet is not a fortune teller. A prophet is someone who stands in public and tells a government what it is doing, in the name of a God the government also claims. That is the whole job, and it explains why so many of them are run out of town, imprisoned, or killed. Almost nothing in these seventeen books is about the distant future; nearly all of it is about the harvest, the courts, the treasury, the treaty, and who is being crushed this season.

The form is consistent. An accusation naming a specific injustice, a verdict, and then very often a reversal — the promise that after collapse something is rebuilt. Empires like the third part and are nervous about the first, so a state religion teaches the prophets as comfort literature and hopes nobody reads the accusations closely enough to notice they are itemised: unjust weights, seized land, bribed judges, unpaid workers, widows without recourse, refugees turned away.

Two other things. The prophets attack worship itself, viciously, when it coexists with exploitation — the festivals are hated, the offerings refused, the singing called noise. There is no more anti-clerical literature in existence and it is in the canon. And false prophecy is a live theme here, with a test that is not accuracy but courage: the false prophet is the one who tells power what it wants to hear.

> *"I hate your festivals. Take away the noise of your songs. Let justice roll down like waters."*
>
> AMOS 5.21–24, CONDENSED

WHAT DOMINION DOES WITH THEM

Reads the consolation passages at state occasions and treats the accusations as historical — a complaint against ancient kings, long settled. The office of prophet is folded into the priesthood, so anyone claiming it independently is by definition unlicensed.

WHAT THIS GIVES TKC

A tradition of sanctioned public speech against the state, sitting inside the Empire's own scripture. Your dissident does not need a new ideology — she needs a lectionary and the nerve to read the unabridged version aloud.

WHO IN MY NOVEL IS A PROPHET, AND WHO DECIDES *write here*

ISAIAH

sixty-six chapters · Book xxiii of lxvi

OT | PROPHET

START HERE

Ch. 1 · 6 · 11 · 40 · 53 · 56 · 58

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

Across three crises and, most scholars think, three sets of hands: a kingdom under Assyrian threat, then the exile, then the disappointing return. One scroll, three eras, and the seams are visible.

WHAT HAPPENS

It opens by telling a devout nation that God is sick of its worship because its hands are full of blood. Then judgment, a throne-room vision, and the great reversals — swords into farm tools, a child ruler, a banquet for all peoples. Later a figure appears who is despised, silent, and destroyed on other people's behalf. It ends with a new earth and a promise aimed squarely at eunuchs and foreigners.

WHO MATTERS

Isaiah · Ahaz · Hezekiah · Cyrus, a foreign king called God's anointed · the suffering servant

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether God's people are the point or the instrument. It keeps widening the circle — to the nations, to the excluded, to a foreign emperor — and every widening rebukes somebody's purity project.

"Your hands are full of blood." ISA 1.15

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The Empire's grandest liturgical language and its sharpest indictment in one scroll. Also the servant figure: authority through humiliation, the one model of power Dominion cannot use.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Quote the coming king constantly and never read chapter one aloud. The promise to eunuchs and foreigners is footnoted as future and spiritual.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Jesus & Kingdom, p. 156; Liturgy Bank, p. 250.

JEREMIAH · LAMENTATIONS

Books xxiv–xxv · the collapse, and the sound a city makes afterwards

JEREMIAH

fifty-two chapters

Forty years of telling a capital city that it is going to fall, and being hated for it. He is put in the stocks, thrown down a cistern, tried for treason, and accused of demoralising the troops — all by his own government, all while the official prophets promise the city cannot be taken. He is right. It falls. His scroll is burned by the king page by page as it is read aloud, so he dictates it again.

His complaints to God are bitter enough to be embarrassing: he accuses God of deceiving him and curses the day he was born. And in the middle of the siege he buys a field, on the record, as a bet that there will be a country again.

For TKC: the licensed prophets versus the one who is tried for treason. Also the burned scroll, and the fact that he simply rewrote it.

LAMENTATIONS

five chapters

Five formal poems written over the ruins of the city, four of them alphabetical acrostics — grief given the strictest possible structure, because structure is the only thing left. It describes famine, mothers and children, and the silence of God without excusing any of it, and it does not resolve. One passage in the middle says mercy is new every morning; the book does not pretend that settles anything.

For TKC: the register for your worst chapter. Grief as a disciplined public form rather than a breakdown — and a text the Empire cannot ban, because it is scripture, and cannot use, because it blames the leadership.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Teach Jeremiah as a warning about national sin rather than about state censorship, and read only the mercy verse from Lamentations, on one fixed day of the year.

CONTESTED

Whether the fall was punishment or simply what happens to small states between empires. Jeremiah says the first; the events also support the second.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

EZEKIEL · DANIEL

Books xxvi–xxvii · both written from inside somebody else's empire

EZEKIEL

forty-eight chapters

A deported priest with no temple to serve in, receiving visions of extravagant strangeness: wheels of eyes, a glory that leaves the temple and moves east with the refugees, a valley of dry bones reassembling into an army. He performs his messages instead of speaking them — lying on one side for months, cooking over dung, shaving his head — and when his wife dies he is told not to mourn publicly, as a sign.

His indictment of the shepherds of Israel is one of the sharpest attacks on a ruling class in the collection: you fed yourselves, you clothed yourselves in the wool, you did not seek the lost. And he insists on individual responsibility — a child does not inherit a parent's guilt, which cuts directly against collective punishment.

For TKC: the mobile God. If the glory leaves the temple and travels with the deported, then no state can hold it by holding the building.

DANIEL

twelve chapters

Half court stories, half apocalypse, and the whole book is about how to keep your integrity inside a regime that owns your career. Young captives are trained for imperial service and renamed; they negotiate over food, refuse to bow to a statue, survive a furnace, and interpret the dreams the empire's own experts cannot. A king goes mad; another sees writing appear on his banquet wall and is dead by morning.

The visions in the second half depict successive empires as beasts and are almost certainly written about a persecution much later than the story's setting — which is exactly how coded resistance literature works.

For TKC: the manual for a character inside the Ministry. Serve competently, refuse at one precise point, and let the refusal be public.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Teach Daniel as a story about personal purity — diet, prayer discipline, courage under trial — and never as a story about refusing to bow to a state image.

WHAT THESE GIVE TKC

Ezekiel's shepherds passage as an indictment of your clergy, and Ezekiel's rule that guilt is not inherited — the passage that dismantles collective punishment.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

THE TWELVE

Books xxviii–xxxii · Hosea through Jonah · short, furious, and mostly about money

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT GIVES TKC
HOSEA	A prophet's marriage staged as national metaphor: infidelity, and a God who keeps taking the nation back. Tender and disturbing in equal measure.	Covenant as marriage — the theology behind Dominion's entire language of wifely duty.
JOEL	A locust plague read as the day of the Lord, ending with a promise that the spirit will be poured out on everyone — sons and daughters, old and young, slaves included.	Prophecy democratised. If daughters prophesy, the Ministry's monopoly is scriptural error.
AMOS	A farmer from the wrong kingdom denounces a prosperous nation for selling the poor for a pair of sandals, and is told to go home. Nine chapters of economics.	The most quotable indictment of a comfortable religious state in existence.
OBADIAH	One chapter, aimed at a neighbouring nation for standing by and profiting while a city was sacked.	Complicity as its own crime — the bystander province.
JONAH	A satire. A prophet runs from an assignment to preach to the enemy capital, is swallowed, obeys, succeeds — and then sulks because God spared them.	Mercy extended to the enemy, and a believer who finds that unbearable.

NOTES *write here*

THE TWELVE, CONTINUED

Books xxxiii–xxxix · Micah through Malachi · the Old Testament ends by auditing its own clergy

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT GIVES TKC
MICAH	Judgment on rulers who devour their own people, and then the collection's clearest summary of the whole demand: do justice, love mercy, walk humbly.	Three verbs that fit on a wall — and indict the wall's owner.
NAHUM	The fall of an imperial capital, described with something close to relish.	What the provinces sing when the centre burns.
HABAKKUK	A prophet who argues with God about why injustice is permitted, gets an unsatisfying answer, and decides to trust anyway.	Faith as an argument you lose and stay in.
ZEPHANIAH	A total judgment on the ruling class, court officials named first, with a small remnant of the humble left over.	The purge sermon your Ministry would love, aimed at itself.
HAGGAI	Rebuild the temple, said to a population living in panelled houses while the site sits in rubble.	State religion as a construction project.
ZECHARIAH	Strange night visions, a high priest re-robed in a heavenly courtroom, and a king who arrives on a donkey rather than a warhorse.	Ceremony as legitimation — and power that refuses the cavalry.
MALACHI	An audit of the priesthood: blemished offerings, withheld dues, and men discarding their wives. The last word of the Old Testament is an accusation against clergy.	Corrupt priests, on the record, in the Empire's own book.

WHICH OF THE TWELVE IS BANNED IN DOMINION, AND WHY — *write here*

BOOKS xl–xliii · BEFORE YOU READ THEM

FOUR ACCOUNTS, NOT ONE

Four of these, and they do not match — which is the most useful thing about them. The differences are four communities, decades apart, deciding what mattered about one life. Most people who quote the gospels are quoting a blend of all four that exists in no manuscript, and untangling that blend is the same act of attention your characters will have to perform on Dominion's teaching.

MARK *earliest · shortest*	Urgent and bleak. No birth story. The disciples never understand him, his family thinks he is unwell, and he keeps telling people to say nothing. In the earliest manuscripts it ends with women running from an empty tomb, terrified, telling no one. **Read this one first.**
MATTHEW *the teacher*	Argues that this is the fulfilment of the Law, so it is built as five great blocks of teaching and cites scripture constantly. Its genealogy includes four women of irregular reputation, on purpose. Holds the Sermon on the Mount, the Lord's Prayer, and an entire chapter denouncing religious authorities by title.
LUKE *the reversal*	Keeps women, foreigners and the poor in the frame. It opens with a pregnant teenager singing that the powerful will be pulled off their thrones and the hungry filled, and it is the only gospel that names the women funding the whole operation. Its parables are the most economically pointed in scripture.
JOHN *theology at altitude*	Long discourses, cosmic language, seven signs. It gives the longest theological conversation in the gospels to a foreign woman at a well, has Martha make the central confession of faith, and makes Mary Magdalene the first resurrection witness — sent to tell men who do not believe her.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Publish one harmonised life of Christ and retire the four. A single official account cannot be cross-examined, and the women at the tomb can be edited into a footnote.

WHAT THIS GIVES TKC

A character who finds two accounts that disagree. Not a crisis of faith — a crisis about who did the editing, which is far more dangerous.

WHICH GOSPEL DOES DOMINION PREACH FROM *write here*

ACTS

twenty-eight chapters · Book xliv of lxvi

NT | RESISTANCE

START HERE

Ch. 2 · 4–5 · 8 · 15 · 16

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

An illegal movement spreading across the Roman world with no buildings, no budget and no legal standing — mostly in rented rooms, borrowed houses and courtrooms.

WHAT HAPPENS

A spirit arrives and everyone hears in their own language. The first community pools its property. Two members are struck dead over money. A persecutor is converted on a road. Then the great fight — whether outsiders must adopt the old law to belong — settled by council. Repeatedly the meeting place is a woman's house.

WHO MATTERS

Peter · Stephen · Paul · **Tabitha** · **Lydia** · **Priscilla** · the Ethiopian official · Gamaliel

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Who is allowed in, and who decides. Every expansion of the boundary in this book is resisted first by insiders, then accepted after somebody tells a story about what they saw.

"They had everything in common." ACTS 2.44

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

A working model for an underground network: house meetings, women as hosts and patrons, decisions made by argument, and a shared purse. Everything your resistance needs, sourced from scripture.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Read it as the founding of the institution rather than the story of an unlicensed movement. The shared property becomes a temporary emergency measure; the women's houses become hospitality.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Lydia, p. 128; Religious Institutions, p. 205.

BOOKS xlv–lxv · BEFORE YOU READ ANY OF THEM

HOW TO READ A LETTER

Twenty-one of the twenty-seven books in this half are letters, and almost every doctrine any empire has built on them depends on forgetting that. These are not treatises. They are one side of a correspondence, written to a named group in a specific mess, and read as if you had found a single reply in someone's desk drawer without the original complaint.

So the discipline is simple. Before extracting any rule, ask what problem the writer is answering, whether the instruction is addressed to a whole community or one household or one troublemaker, and whether the same author says something different elsewhere. He very often does — the man who tells one congregation that women should be silent greets women running congregations in another letter, names one an apostle, and calls another a deacon by title.

CONTESTED

Whether the household codes are timeless order or first-century accommodation, and whether the silencing verses are original to the letter at all — some manuscripts place them differently, which is a live argument.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Teach the letters as legislation, print them without their addressees, and never mention that the woman who carried the most important one was trusted to explain it.

THE BIG FOUR	**Romans** — the long argument about who belongs and on what basis; carried and probably explained by a woman named as a deacon. **1 Corinthians** — a congregation tearing itself apart over status, food and sex; holds the love chapter nobody reads in context. **Galatians** — furious, about whether outsiders must assimilate to belong. **Ephesians** — where the household code sits, directly under the mutual-submission line.
THE SHORT ONES	**Philippians** — written from prison, unreasonably joyful, and holding a hymn about power surrendered. **Colossians**, **1–2 Thessalonians** — early, apocalyptic, practical. **Philemon** — a private note about an enslaved man, and the single most argued-over page in the abolition debate.
THE PASTORALS	**1–2 Timothy**, **Titus** — church management: who may teach, who may be appointed, how widows are enrolled. The most institutional documents here, the most disputed in authorship, and the source of Dominion's clergy handbook. Note the pattern: the letters scholars most doubt are the ones most concerned with hierarchy.
THE GENERAL LETTERS	**Hebrews** — a sustained argument that the old sacrificial system is finished. **James** — brutally direct about the rich, favouritism in the assembly, and faith that produces nothing. **1–2 Peter**, **1–3 John**, **Jude** — how to stay faithful while powerless, plus warnings about teachers in it for the money.